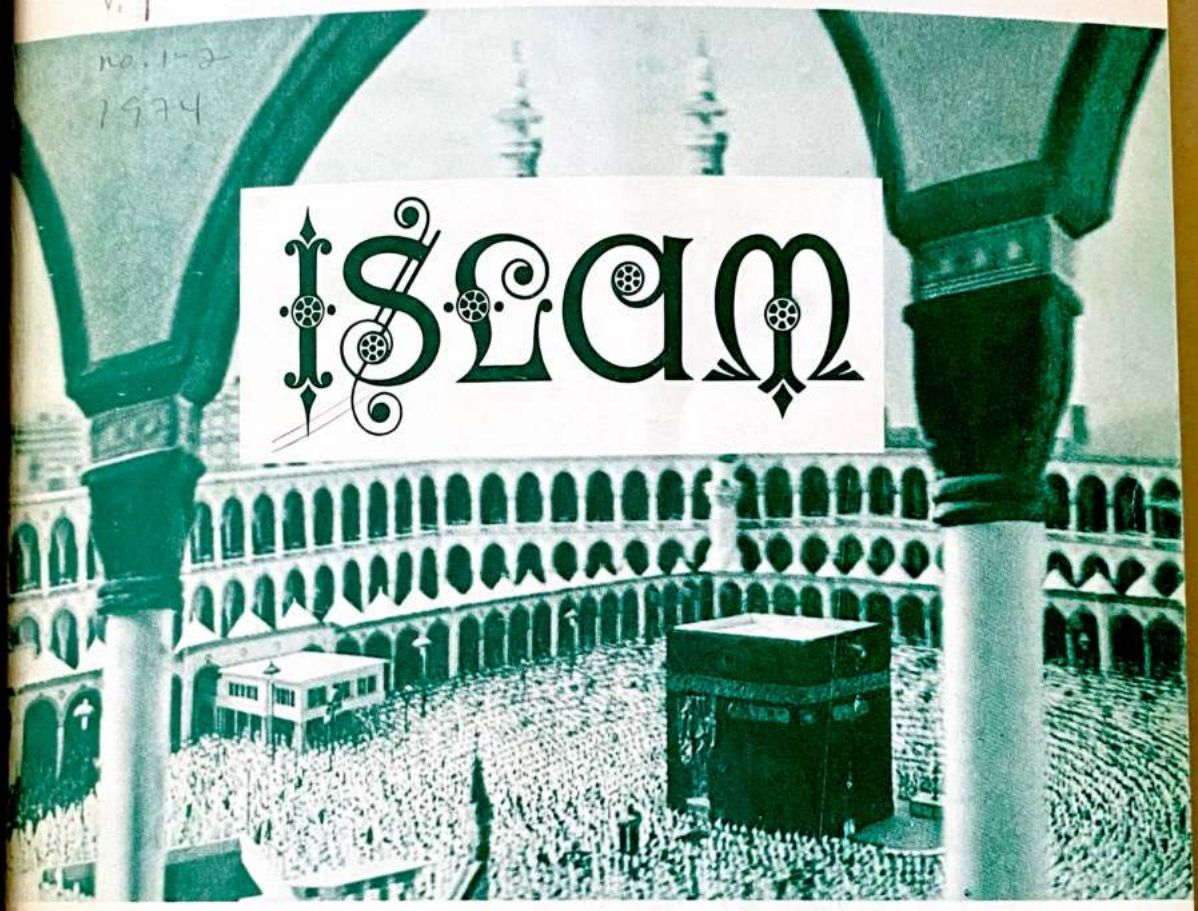
بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

B-228
BP
1
.I57
v. 1
no. 1-2
1974

VOLUME 1 • Rabī' I, 1394 April, 1974 • NUMBER 1



ISLAM

An International Journal Expressing the Islamic Point of View

EDITORS

Dr. Muḥammad 'Abdul-Rauf (Washington, D.C., U.S.A.)
Dr. Mujāhid Al-Ṣawwāf (Mecca, Saudi Arabia)
Dr. Sherif El-Ḥakım (St. Louis, Missouri, U.S.A.)
Dr. Rashād Khalīfa (St. Louis, Missouri, U.S.A.)
S. Shāhid Mufassir (Palmer Park, Maryland, U.S.A.)
Dr. Hārūn Nasution (Jakarta, Indonesia)
Dr. Altan Necioğlu (Ankara, Turkey)
Dr. Aḥmad H. Ṣaqr (Lombard, Illinois U.S.A.)
Muḥammad Sirājuddīn (Hyderabad, India)
Dr. Yūsuf Amīn Wālī (Cairo, Egypt)

PUBLISHED QUARTERLY *by*

Islamic Productions International, Inc.

COPYRIGHT © 1974, ISLAMIC PRODUCTIONS INTERNATIONAL, INC.
PRINTED IN THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم

اللهم بسطوة جبروت قهرك وبسرعة إغاثة نصرك وبغير تك لانتهاك حرماتك وبحمايتك لمن احتمى بآياتك أسألك يا الله يا سميع يا قريب يا مجيب يا سريع يا منتقم يا شديد البطش يا جبار يا قهار يا من لا يعجزه قهر الجبابرة ولا يعظم عليه هلاك المتمردة من الملوك والأكاسرة أن تجعل كيد من كادني في نحره ومكر من مكر بي عائدا عليه وحفرة من حفر لي واقعا فيها ومن نصب لي شبكة الخداع اجعله يا سيدي مساقا إليها ومصادفا فيها وأسيرا لديها اللهم بحق كهيعص اكفناهم العدا ولقهم الردى واجعلهم لكل حبيب فدا وسلط عليهم عاجل النقمة في اليوم والغد. اللهم بدد شملهم، اللهم فرق جمعهم اللهم أقلل عددهم، اللهم فل حدهم، اللهم اجعل الدائرة عليهم اللهم أرسل العذاب إليهم، اللهم أخرجهم عن دائرة الحلم واسلبهم مدد الإمهال وغل أيديهم واربط على قلوبهم ولا تبلغهم الآمال، اللهم مزقهم كل ممزق مزقته لأعدائك

انتصارا لأنبيائك ورسلك وأوليائك اللهم انتصر لنا انتصارك لأحبابك على أعدائك، اللهم لا تمكن الأعداء فينا ولا تسلطهم علينا بذنوبنا حم حم حم حم حم حم حم حم حم الأمر وجاء النصر فعلينا لا ينصرون حمعسق حمايتنا مما نخاف، اللهم قنا شر الأسواء ولا تجعلنا محلا للبلواء، اللهم أعطنا أمل الرجاء وفوق الأمل يا هو يا هو يا هو يا من بفضله لفضله نسألك - نسألك العجل العجل إلهي الإجابة الإجابة يا من أجاب نوحا في قومه يا من نصر إبراهيم على أعدائه يا من رد يوسف على يعقوب يا من كشف ضر أيوب يا من أجاب دعوة زكريا يا من قبل تسبيح يونس بن متى نسألك بأسرار أصحاب هذه الدعوات أن تقبل ما به دعوناك وأن تعطينا ما سألناك أنجز لنا وعدك الذي وعدته لعبادك المؤمنين لا إله إلا أنت سبحانك إني كنت من الظالمين انقطعت آمالنا وعزتك إلا أمنك وخاب رجاؤنا وحقك إلا فيك.

إن أبطأت غارة الأرحام وابتعدت
فأقرب السير مني غارة الله
يا غارة الله جدي السير مسرعة
في حل عقدتنا يا غارة الله
عدت العادون وجاروا
ورجونا الله مجيرا
وكفى بالله وليا
وكفى بالله نصيرا
حسبنا الله ونعم الوكيل
حسبنا الله ونعم الوكيل
حسبنا الله ونعم الوكيل
ولا حول ولا قوة إلا بالله العلي العظيم استجب لنا آمين
لا حول ولا قوة إلا بالله العلي العظيم استجب لنا آمين
لا حول ولا قوة إلا بالله العلي العظيم استجب لنا آمين
فقطع دابر القوم الذين ظلموا والحمد لله رب العالمين

وصلى الله على سيدنا محمد النبي الأمي وعلى آله وصحبه وسلم ؟

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

قُل لَّوْ كَانَ الْبَحْرُ مِدَادًا لِّكَلِمَاتِ رَبِّي

لَنَفِدَ الْبَحْرُ قَبْلَ أَن تَنفَدَ كَلِمَاتُ رَبِّي

وَلَوْ جِئْنَا بِمِثْلِهِ مَدَدًا

IN THE NAME OF GOD, THE COMPASSIONATE, THE MERCIFUL

Say, "If the ocean were an ink-well for the words of my Lord, the ocean would run out before the words of my Lord run out, even if twice as much ink were provided."

(Qur'an 18:109)

Notes to Authors

It the policy of this Journal to publish articles in English in all fields of ISLAM provided they are of a high caliber and contribute to the fundamental knowledge of the religion. In keeping with the universal nature of Islam, this journal is not intended to reflect any political, regional, or nationalistic bias. Articles containing unwarranted attacks, direct or implied, against any other religion, sect, belief, or ideology, shall not be accepted for publication. The journal's sole objective is to work within the framework of ISLAM towards a full appreciation of God's message to all humanity.

The journal recognizes the sources of Islamic knowledge to be the Qur'an, the Sunna, analogy (Qiyās), consensus (Ijmā'), and personal thought (Ijtihād). However, THE QUR'AN shall be the ultimate reference. Only statements in full agreement with the Qur'an shall represent the journal's official stand. All other statements, or statements subject to various interpretations shall represent only the author's personal viewpoint.

Manuscripts submitted for publication should be typed, double spaced. Only one copy is required. All Qur'anic quotations must be accompanied by the number(s) of sura(s), and the number(s) of verse(s). Colons should separate the number of sura from the number(s) of verse(s) (e.g. 17:28-33). A group of verses from the same sura should be separated from each other by commas (e.g. 17:28-33, 51, 60-62). When more than one sura are involved, a semi-colon should separate the different suras (e.g. 17:28-33, 51, 60-62; 23:16; 36:9-11, 19-25, 44). The journal will undertake to add the Arabic text to all Qur'anic translations. This is to avoid the inadvertent mental re-translation to an Arabic composition which is different from the original.

Every Ḥadīth should be accompanied by its sources (transmitters) and the reference book where it may be found. If the transmitter(s) and/or the reference book were not known, this should be stated clearly.

Notes to Authors

It the policy of this Journal to publish articles in English in all fields of ISLAM provided they are of a high caliber and contribute to the fundamental knowledge of the religion. In keeping with the universal nature of Islam, this journal is not intended to reflect any political, regional, or nationalistic bias. Articles containing unwarranted attacks, direct or implied, against any other religion, sect, belief, or ideology, shall not be accepted for publication. The journal's sole objective is to work within the framework of ISLAM towards a full appreciation of God's message to all humanity.

The journal recognizes the sources of Islamic knowledge to be the Qur'an, the Sunna, analogy (Qiyās), consensus (Ijmā'), and personal thought (Ijtihād). However, THE QUR'AN shall be the ultimate reference. Only statements in full agreement with the Qur'an shall represent the journal's official stand. All other statements, or statements subject to various interpretations shall represent only the author's personal viewpoint.

Manuscripts submitted for publication should be typed, double spaced. Only one copy is required. All Qur'anic quotations must be accompanied by the number(s) of sura(s), and the number(s) of verse(s). Colons should separate the number of sura from the number(s) of verse(s) (e.g. 17:28-33). A group of verses from the same sura should be separated from each other by commas (e.g. 17:28-33, 51, 60-62). When more than one sura are involved, a semi-colon should separate the different suras (e.g. 17:28-33, 51, 60-62; 23:16; 36:9-11, 19-25, 44). The journal will undertake to add the Arabic text to all Qur'anic translations. This is to avoid the inadvertent mental re-translation to an Arabic composition which is different from the original.

Every Ḥadīth should be accompanied by its sources (transmitters) and the reference book where it may be found. If the transmitter(s) and/or the reference book were not known, this should be stated clearly.

Transliteration of Arabic words and names should follow the convention shown below. The only vowels should be: i (as in ibn), a (as in Aḥmad), u (as in ummah), ī (as in tafsīr), ā (as in āyāt), and ū (as in Hūd).

A Convention for the Pronunciation and Transliteration of the Arabic Alphabet

Alphabet	Pronunciation	English Equivalent
ا	Alif	A
ب	Bā	B
ت	Tā	T (as in Table)
ث	Thā	Th (as in Think)
ج	Jīm	G, J
ح	Ḥā	Ḥ
خ	Kha	Kh
د	Dāl	D (as in Doubt)
ذ	Dhal	Th (as in Then)
ر	Rā	R
ز	Zayn	Z (as in Zoo)
س	Sīn	S (as in Sit)
ش	Shīn	Sh
ص	Ṣād	Ṣ (as in Sun)
ض	Ḍad	Ḍ (as in Double)
ط	Ṭā	Ṭ (as in Tub)
ظ	Ẓā	Ẓ (as in Zombi)
ع	'Ayn	'A, 'U, 'I
غ	Ghayn	Gh (French R)
ف	Fā	F
ق	Qāf	Q
ك	Kāf	K
ل	Lām	L
م	Mīm	M
ن	Nūn	N
ه	Hā	H
و	Wow	W
ي	Yā	Y

ISLAM

A publication of Islamic Productions International, Inc.

VOLUME 1 • Rabī' I, 1394 April, 1974 • NUMBER 1

CONTENTS

The Bible's Preview of Muḥammad 1
Sulaymān Shāhid Mufassir

The Qur'an and Christianity 15
Pope Shenūda III

Islam: Was It Spread by the Sword? 29
Dr. Yūsuf Amīn Wālī

English Meanings of the Qur'an : 1 40
Dr. Rashād Khalīfa

Islam: Its Mission in the World
1. Unity of Religious Belief 57
Dr. M. Farīd Wajdī

Islamic Concentrates:

The Aphorisms of Salāmah Al-Rāḍī 63
The Invocations of 'Abdullah Anṣārī 67
Index to the Qur'an 71
The Islamic Calendar Conversion Table 77

Book Review 81

092826-221

by Sulaymān Shāhid Mufassir

The Bible's Preview of Muḥammad

Despite the disastrous human interference in the holy writings of the Torah and the Gospel, as admitted by the Bible's publishers, the scriptures still contain a goodly portion of the original truth. So much so that those who truly believe and follow the Bible, even in its present form, will certainly be guided to Islam (Qur'an 2:121). Those who honestly follow the teachings of Moses and Jesus (may God bestow blessings and peace upon them), even in their current state, will be led to the completion and fulfillment of what their creator expects of them. This has been the experience of many free-minded followers of the Bible. One such example is the author of this article. As a former ordained Christian minister, Sulaymān Shāhid Mufassir recounts the biblical guidance which led him to the light of Islam.

THE BIBLE contains a vivid preview of the person and mission of Muḥammad (peace be upon him) that is so distinct and unmistakable that many a sincere Jew and Christian was happy to accept him as the prophet when he appeared. But over the subsequent centuries of theological antagonism, preceded and accompanied by the editing, rewriting and dogmatizing of portions of the scriptural record, that written portrait has become obscured as with a thick layer of dust. When the centuries-old encrustations of dogma and sectarian hermeneutics are removed, many well-known, little understood verses of the Bible serve as signposts for the serious scholar.

The Role of the Bible

Muslims believe that the original Torah and Gospel were revealed by Almighty God. When Jesus began to call the Jews to return to sincere and devoted service to God, the Torah of Moses had been subjected to serious instances of careless copying and dogmatic editing, but he confirmed in his preaching whatever remained intact of the divine revelation. He said, "Do not suppose that I have come to abolish the Law (Torah) and the prophets; I did not come to abolish, but to complete. I tell you this: so long as heaven and earth endure, not a letter, not a stroke, will disappear from the Law

until all that must happen has happened"(1). The essence of the Torah was confirmed in the Gospel. Six hundred years after the Gospel, when it had similarly suffered through careless copying and editing, Muḥammad resumed the prophetic mission and confirmed whatever had remained of both the Torah and the Gospel. He received from God the clarified book, the Qur'an, which would be protected forever from error and distortion, and which would therefore *serve* as the protector or *the ultimate reference* (muhaimin) of all previous revelations(2).

The Bible does not now contain the Torah and Gospel as they were divinely revealed. Biblical scholars themselves have recognized the human nature and composition of the book(3). However, we may expect to find within its pages some portion of the Torah and the Gospel, although careful study is necessary in order to make the message comprehensible(4). An amazing feature of the Bible, even in its present form, is that it indicates the divine revelation would progress through a number of message-bearers or prophets and be completed finally in one man, one particular prophet whose message would be so comprehensive and whose mission would be so universal that no further prophets would ever be needed.

It is easy for God to speak with distinction of things thousands of years prior to their occurrence, but impossible for man to do so. According to the Old Testament, the faithfulness of Abraham was given special reward by a covenant or promise to bless all mankind through his descendants. His line would be distinguished by divine guidance and prophecy. "By Myself have I sworn, saith the Lord, because thou hast done this thing, and hast not withheld thy son, thine only son, that in blessing I will bless thee, and in multiplying I will multiply thy seed as the stars of the heaven, and as the sand which is upon the seashore . . . and in thy seed shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because thou hast hearkened to My voice"(5).

The Bible is the record, primarily, of God's favor to Abraham's second son Isaac, in whose line came Moses and Jesus, peace be upon them. But what about the first-born of Abraham, Ishmael?

The Genesis story about the turning out of Ishmael and his mother, Hagar, the Egyptian servant woman of Sarah, due to Sarah's jealousy in being unable to bear the first son of Abraham, is an early example of Hebrew chauvinism, full of contradictory elements(6). In effect, Genesis closes the door on Hagar and Ishmael; from henceforth only Isaac and Sarah matter. But God's promise to Abraham was not biased. When He made the "everlasting covenant" with the family of Abraham, Isaac was not even in the picture. Ishmael was his only son and God declared: "As for Ishmael, I have heard thee; behold I have blessed him . . . twelve princes shall he beget, and I will make him a great nation"(7).

Double Honor due to Ishmael's Line

The writers of Genesis wrongly attempted to make it appear that Ishmael would receive an inferior blessing because his mother was a servant woman, but Isaac, being the son of the free woman, would inherit the glory of the first-born son. In so doing, they disregarded the clear family laws of the Torah. According to this law, the rights of the first-born son are not invalid due to the social status of his mother. This applied especially in polygamous marriages such as that of Abraham(8). Man's social prejudices do not in any way dictate the favor of God. According to the Torah:

כִּי־תִהְיֶיןָ לְאִישׁ
שְׁתֵּי נָשִׁים הָאַחַת אֲהוּבָה וְהָאַחַת שְׂנוּאָה
וְיָלְדוּ־לוֹ בָנִים הָאֲהוּבָה וְהַשְּׂנוּאָה
וְהָיָה הַבֵּן הַבְּכֹר לַשְּׂנוּאָה: וְהָיָה בְּיוֹם
הַנְחִילוֹ אֶת־בָּנָיו אֵת אֲשֶׁר־יִהְיֶה לוֹ

לֹא יוּכַל לְבַכֵּר אֶת־בֶּן־הָאֲהוּבָה
עַל־פְּנֵי בֶן־הַשְּׂנוּאָה הַבְּכֹר: כִּי אֶת־
הַבְּכֹר בֶּן־הַשְּׂנוּאָה יַכִּיר לָתֵת לוֹ פִּי
שְׁנַיִם בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר־יִמָּצֵא לוֹ כִּי־הוּא
רֵאשִׁית אֹנוֹ לוֹ מִשְׁפַּט הַבְּכֹרָה:

"If a man has two wives, one loved and the other unloved (i.e., slighted or socially despised due to inferior social status), and both the loved and the unloved have borne him sons, but the first-born is the son of the unloved wife, when he wills his property to his sons, he may not treat as first-born the son of the loved one in disregard of the son of the unloved one who is older. Instead he must accept the first-born, the son of the unloved one, and allot him a double portion of all he possesses; since he is the first fruit of his vigor, the birthright is his due"(9).

But the Bible disregards this fair principle and gives throughout the "double portion" of honor to Isaac, the second son and makes it actually appear that the "birthright" is his (Cf. Genesis 17:21: "but My covenant will I establish with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear . . ."). This makes the "Torah" of the Bible a contradictory law. By right, the *double honor* and the birthright belong to the line of Ishmael, and the "unloved" social status of his mother detracts from this not at all.

Ishmael's descendants came to be known as Arabs, a term which, in Hebrew, meant those who inhabited the *'arabah* or desert (10). It is not a coincidence that of the twelve sons of Ishmael (Genesis 25:12-16) the one mentioned most prominently is Qaydar (*Qedar* in Hebrew). In some Bible verses, Qaydar is synonymous with the Arabs in general(11). This is an important indication that the line of Qaydar was marked by God for a unique purpose, to bring forth the one whose life and work would bring "a double portion" of honor to the house of Ishmael.

The nature of this twofold honor begins to be revealed in the Old Testament book of Isaiah. There are many brilliant parables and prophecies in Isaiah which concern the fulfillment of God's promise to bless all mankind

through the family of Abraham. Christians believe that some of these accounts relate to the gentle but forthright mission of Jesus as the Messiah. But the 42nd chapter of Isaiah is distinct because it points, not to the Hebrew, but to the Arab branch of Abraham's family. Here Isaiah points out a chosen "Servant of the Lord" who would have a prophethood to all mankind, unlike the Hebrew prophets whose mission was limited to Israel. God's spirit would guide him and he would establish justice on earth. He would not rule as a loud or boisterous demagogue. Unlike the brief ministry of Jesus, this prophet would serve long enough to "set right in the earth," to actually establish a society or community based on truth and justice. He would be "a light of the nations." What is most startling about this particular servant of the Lord is that he, alone, is *identified with Qaydar* in verse 11.

׀ הֵן עַבְדִּי אֶתְמָךְ־בּוֹ	׀ כֹּה־אָמַר הָאֵל ׀ יְהוָה
בְּחִירִי רָצְתָה נַפְשִׁי	בּוֹרֵא הַשָּׁמַיִם וְנוֹטֵיהֶם
נָתַתִּי רוּחִי עָלָיו	רֹקַע הָאָרֶץ וְצֶאֱצָאֶיהָ
מִשְׁפָּט לַגּוֹיִם יוֹצִיא:	נֹתֵן נְשָׁמָה לָעָם עָלֶיהָ
2 לֹא יִצְעַק וְלֹא יִשָּׂא	וְרוּחַ לַהֹלְכִים בָּהּ:
וְלֹא־יַשְׁמִיעַ בַּחוּץ קוֹלוֹ:	6 אֲנִי יְהוָה קְרָאתִיךָ בְצֶדֶק
3 קָנֶה רָצוּץ לֹא יִשְׁבּוֹר	וְאַחֲזִק בְּיָדֶךָ
וּפִשְׁתָּה כֵהָה לֹא יְכַבֶּנָּה	וְאֶצָּרְךָ וְאֶתֶּנְךָ לִבְרִית עָם
לֶאֱמֶת יוֹצִיא מִשְׁפָּט:	לְאוֹר גּוֹיִם:
4 לֹא יִכְהֶה וְלֹא יָרוּץ	11 יִשְׂאוּ מִדְבָּר וְעָרָיו
עַד־יָשִׂים בָּאָרֶץ מִשְׁפָּט	חֲצֵרִים תֵּשֵׁב קֵדָר
וּלְתוֹרָתוֹ אִיִּים יְיַחֵלוּ:	יָרֹנּוּ יֹשְׁבֵי סֶלַע
	מֵרֹאשׁ הָרִים יִצְוָחוּ:

"Here is My servant, whom I uphold, My chosen one in whom I delight, I have bestowed My spirit upon him, and he will make justice shine on the nations. He will not call out or lift his voice high, or make himself heard in the open market. He will not break a bruised reed, or snuff out a smouldering wick; he will make justice shine on every race, never faltering, never breaking down, he will plant justice on earth, while coasts and islands wait for his teaching. Thus speaks the Lord Who is God, He Who created the skies and stretched them out, Who fashioned the earth and all that grows in it, Who gave breath to its people, the breath of life to all who walk upon it: I, the Lord, have called you with righteous purpose and taken you by the hand; I have formed you and appointed you to be a light to all peoples, a beacon for the nations . . . Let the wilderness and its towns rejoice, and the villages of the tribe of Kedar (Qaydar)"(12).

This prophecy could apply to none of the Hebrew prophets. Even Jesus made it plain that his mission was far from being universal, saying: "I am not sent but unto the lost sheep of the house of Israel"(13). His calling was

limited and it was the later Gentile converts, not Jesus, who gave Christianity its inclusive nature. Nor was Jesus or any of the Hebrew prophets related in any way to "Kedar" (Qaydar). In promising a great prophet from the Arabs, Isaiah was merely amplifying the prophecy made previously by Moses. God revealed to Moses that a prophet would arise from the *brothers* of the Hebrews — the Arabs, who were children of the brother of Isaac, Ishmael — who would command world-wide attention and obedience:

נָבִיא אָקִים לָהֶם מִקֶּרֶב אֲחֵיהֶם
כָּמוֹךָ וְנָתַתִּי דְבָרַי בְּפִיו וְדִבֶּר אֲלֵיהֶם
אֵת כָּל־אֲשֶׁר אֲצַוֶּנּוּ: וְהָיָה הָאִישׁ
אֲשֶׁר לֹא־יִשְׁמַע אֶל־דְּבָרַי אֲשֶׁר יְדַבֵּר
בִּשְׁמִי אָנֹכִי אֶדְרֹשׁ מֵעִמּוֹ:

"I will raise them up a Prophet from among their brethren, like unto thee, and will put My words in his mouth, and he shall speak unto them all that I shall command him. And it shall come to pass, that whosoever will not hearken unto My words which he shall speak in My name, I will require it of him"(14). This prophet would have to be "like unto thee (Moses)," who was founder, leader and exemplar of a community of believers, one whose mission would last long enough to achieve cohesive, concrete results.

The Gospel Preview: The Paraclete

The Gospel of Jesus brought into sharper focus the identity of the one who would fulfill the promise to make the line of Ishmael a great nation. In the Gospel of John — a New Testament book which is not the Gospel of Jesus and which may be considered as representing only in general terms portions of Jesus' teaching — Jesus informs his close companions that his work among them was drawing to conclusion, but God would send someone else after a time to carry forward the prophetic movement. This someone, however, would be the last of the prophets.

JOHN 14:16, 17:

καὶ 16 ἐγὼ ἐρωτήσω τὸν πατέρα, καὶ ἄλλον παράκλητον
δώσει ὑμῖν, ἵνα μένῃ μεθ' ὑμῶν εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, τὸ 17
πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας

"And I will pray the Father, and He shall give you another Comforter, that he may abide with you forever, even the spirit of truth"(15).

JOHN 16:13, 14:

ὅταν δὲ ἔλθῃ ἐκεῖνος, τὸ πνεῦμα 13
τῆς ἀληθείας, ὁδηγήσει ὑμᾶς εἰς πᾶσαν τὴν ἀλή-
θειαν· οὐ γὰρ λαλήσει ἀφ' ἑαυτοῦ, ἀλλ' ὅσα ἂν
ἀκούσῃ λαλήσει, καὶ τὰ ἐρχόμενα ἀναγγελεῖ ὑμῖν.
ἐκεῖνος ἐμὲ δοξάσει

"When he, the spirit of truth is come, he will guide you unto all truth; for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear (from God), that shall he speak, and he will show you things to come. He shall glorify me"(16).

In Jesus' written portrait of the last messenger he is called the "Comforter," which represents the word *parakletos* in the Greek New Testament. More precisely, *parakletos* means an advocate, one who pleads the cause of another, one who counsels or advises another from deep concern for the other's welfare(17). *Parakletos* would designate one who would be considered the "Mercy for all creatures", *Rahmatun lil 'ālamīn* (Qur'an 21:107). He would be the counsellor who would "lead forth those who believe and do righteous deeds from the depths of darkness into light" (Qur'an 65:11), the true advocate who would be *ḥarīṣun 'alaykum* (Sura Al-Tawba); *genuinely solicitous* for the welfare of humanity, pleading their case with God and showing them the sure way of return to the favor of the divine Judge.

THE GREEK WORD "PARACLETE" (Ho Parakletos):

ὁ παράκλητος

However, some scholars believe that what Jesus said in his own language of Aramaic represents more closely the Greek word *periklytos,* which means the Admirable or Glorified One. *Periklytos* corresponds to the word *Muḥammad* in Arabic(18). There are several proven cases of similar word substitutions in the New Testament. There are also several instances of another possibility, the possibility that the Greek text originally had *both* words, *parakletos* and *periklytos,* and due to the similarity of spelling and close proximity to one another in the sentence, one got left out by the copyists. In such case the Greek text would have read: ΚΑΙ ΑΛΛΟΝ ΠΑΡΑΚΛΗΤΟΝ ΤΟΝ ΠΕΡΙΚΛΥΤΟΣ ΔΩΣΕΙ ΥΜΙΝ instead of the present reading: ΚΑΙ ΑΛΛΟΝ ΠΑΡΑΚΛΗΤΟΝ ΔΩΣΕΙ ΥΜΙΝ that is, "and He will give you another Counsellor, the Admirable One," instead of the present reading, "and He will give you another Counsellor." Such mistakes occurred in copying because the ancient texts had all the letters written close together. The eye of the copyist could easily pass over a word similar in spelling or close in position(19).

When Jesus declares of this coming prophet-counsellor that he would "abide with you forever," he shows that there would be no need for additional prophets to succeed him. He would be the last one. He would lead mankind "unto all the truth"(Greek: πᾶσαν τὴν ἀλη θειαν· "to the whole truth," "to every aspect of the truth."); there would be no necessity for anyone to come with additional truth. Indeed, there would be no more additional truth, in the general sense, to bring. So truthful and trustworthy would he be that

he could be called *Al-Amîn*, or as the Greek text of John 16:13 says, *τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας*, "the spirit of truth," one of whom it could be said: "He has brought them the Truth." (Qur'an 23:70).

The term "spirit" here does not mean that the coming prophet would be other than human. In New Testament Greek, this word has also been applied to an inspired *person*, "the possessor of a spiritual communication" or revelation. The one who becomes overwhelmed with a divine revelation is himself termed a "spirit"(20). The "spirit of truth" would be the person who would possess a spiritual communication, that is, a divine revelation, and whose life and conduct and character would be marked to an extreme degree by devotion to the truth. This is why the next sentence of the verse containing this expression says: "He will guide you unto all truth; for he shall not speak of himself, but whatsoever he shall hear (from God), that shall he speak." (John 16:13). This person would receive the revelation of truth from God and these words alone would constitute the message, not his own opinions or the writings of his companions. His message or revelation would be first and foremost and literally the Word of God. Note that this corresponds exactly to what God revealed to Moses about the prophet who would come from among the "brothers" of the Hebrews: "I . . . will put My words in his mouth, and he shall speak unto them all that I shall command him." (Deuteronomy 18:18).

A more striking point is the similarity between the divine mission given to Moses, Jesus and the Spirit of Truth (Muḥammad) as bearers of a single thread of Revelation from God. By comparing Deuteronomy 18:15, 17-19; John 12:49; 16:12-13; and Qur'an 73:15, one observes that despite the thousands of years involved and the disastrous human interference in the Bible, the words describing these three personalities are almost identical. Therefore, the (original) Torah, Gospel and the Qur'an have One Source and reveal the same Truth, which is Eternal.

It cannot be overlooked that Jesus gives a unique requirement that would help to identify the last prophet: "He shall glorify me." (John 16:14). If anyone had come claiming to be this prophet, but did not give due honor to Jesus as prophet and Messiah, he would be the wrong one. As a nation, the Jews rejected Jesus. At the same time, this prophet to come would not be a follower of Jesus, that is, a Christian, because Jesus said that this prophet would reveal things of which Jesus himself was unaware. If Jesus had brought "all the truth," there would have been no need for him to single out someone else who would come with all the truth. Likewise, since this prophet would bring all the truth he would have to be the last one, the seal of the prophets. Therefore, we would have to look for someone who, like Abraham in whose line he would come, would be neither Jew nor Christian but would believe

in God. Unlike the Jews as a whole, he would "glorify" Jesus by insisting that Jesus was a true messenger of God and by acknowledging that Jesus was the true Messiah. But the teaching of this prophet would come from God Himself. As a revelation from God, the message of this last prophet would confirm what God had revealed previously by means of the original Torah and the original Gospel, *but his message would be no mere plagiarized copy,* no "condensed edition" of either the Torah or the Gospel. God Almighty had said, "I ... will put My words in his mouth," and it is proper that these words would agree with previously revealed words of the One and Same God. "Whatsoever he shall hear (from God), that shall he speak."

The one reference at John 14:26 which seeks to identify the coming prophet as "the Holy Ghost" or Spirit is the only one like it in the entire Bible. It is obviously the addition of some editor of the Gospel of John who sought in his own way to explain who he thought the "spirit of truth" was. But this indefensible exegesis simply contradicts what Jesus is reported to have said elsewhere in John. According to other verses he indicated clearly that the prophet or "Paraclete" would not come until Jesus' own mission was finished. The holy spirit — the angel of revelation — was active already, both before and during the ministry of Jesus, delivering God's revelations to His prophets and assisting them. (See Psalms 51:11; Matthew 3:16; 4:1, etc.). This strange "Holy Ghost" interpretation gained currency only after Christians began to look upon God as a "Trinity," with the "Holy Ghost" being an aspect of it. Neither the word Trinity nor its concepts can be found anywhere in the Bible. The Paraclete would be a man, not a ghost, because the same word is applied to Jesus himself at 1 John 2:1:

παράκλητον ἔχομεν πρὸς τὸν πατέρα, Ἰησοῦν Χριστὸν δίκαιον·

"We have a Paraclete (Advocate, Counsellor) with the Father, Jesus Christ, the righteous one." Jesus had been a "paraclete" to the Jews and his followers so considered him, but the Paraclete to come after Jesus (John 14:16) would be for all people, all places and all times.

The Greek text at John 14:16 which foretells the coming of "another Paraclete" is so specific that even the word "another" has significance. In English, "another" may mean "one more of the *same* kind" or "one more of a *different* kind." It is important to know which meaning Jesus had in mind, because if he meant "one more of a *different* kind" that would mean the Paraclete would perhaps be a spirit and the current Christian interpretation has some merit. But if he meant "one more of the *same* kind," then this is positive proof that the Paraclete would be just like Jesus was: a man, a human being, a prophet, NOT a spirit. Which did Jesus mean? The Greek text of the New Testament gives the verdict clearly because it uses the word *allon,* which is the masculine accusative form of *allos*:

"ANOTHER OF THE *SAME* KIND." The Greek word for "another of a different kind" is *heteros,* but the New Testament does not use this word at John 14:16. Clearly, then, the Paraclete would be "ANOTHER OF THE *SAME* KIND" as Jesus, or as Moses said, "Like unto me": a MAN, not a spirit.

Detail of the Revelation

We can now begin to put together the complete "picture" which emerges from the Bible and come up with a very specific, graphic portrait of the messenger whose prominent characteristics are twofold: (1) He would be the last one and (2) he would be universal. According to the information given in the Old and New Testaments, this prophet would:

i. be firm but merciful
ii. establish a community based on justice
iii. be a light for all the nations
iv. be associated with Qaydar;

(All based on Isaiah 42:1-11)

v. be a descendant of Ishmael, a "brother" to the Hebrews
vi. fulfill the promises made to Abraham and Ishmael to
  a. serve as a blessing to all the nations
  b. establish the Arabs as a "great nation"
  c. inherit the "double portion" of honor;
vii. receive revelation directly from God;

(All based on Genesis 17:20; 22:16-18; Deuteronomy 21:15-17)

viii. come after Jesus' mission was ended
ix. comfort and counsel mankind (paraclete), for which he would be known as the praised one (periclyte)
x. be outstanding for his truthfulness
xi. receive words directly from God
xii. deliver "all the truth," the whole truth
xiii. have a ministry of lasting effect
xiv. glorify Jesus.

(All based on John 14:16, 17 and 16:13, 14)

To refine these points for still clearer focus, the last prophet would differ from all the others in at least three vital aspects:

(1) He would have a universal mission

(2) He would be the seal of the prophets

(3) He would be an Arab, and of the 12 sons of Ishmael, he would have to come in the line of Qaydar.

Abraham (Ibrahim) ..... was father o
Ishmael (Ismail) ..... " " "
Kedar (Qaydar) ..... " " "
'Adnān ..... " " "
Ma'add ..... " " "
Nizār ..... " " "
Muḍar ..... " " "
Ilyās ..... " " "
Mudrikah ..... " " "
Khuzaimah ..... " " "
Kinānah ..... " " "
Al-Naḍr ..... " " "
Mālik ..... " " "
Quraysh (Fihr) ..... " " "
Ghālib ..... " " "
Lu'ayy ..... " " "
Ka'ab ..... " " "
Murrah ..... " " "
Kilāb ..... " " "
Quṣayy ..... " " "
'Abd Manāf ..... " " "
Hāshim ..... " " "
'Abdul Muṭṭalib ..... " " "
'Abdullāh ..... " " "

MUḤAMMAD

(See Genesis 25:12-16, and *Muhammad the Holy Prophet* by H. G. Sarwar, pp. 10, 11)

Genealogical Table from Abraham to Muḥammad

(may God bestow peace and blessings upon them)

Abraham (Ibrahim)	was	father	of
Ishmael (Ismail)	"	"	"
Kedar (Qaydar)	"	"	"
ʻAdnān	"	"	"
Maʻadd	"	"	"
Nizār	"	"	"
Muḍar	"	"	"
Ilyās	"	"	"
Mudrikah	"	"	"
Khuzaimah	"	"	"
Kinānah	"	"	"
Al-Naḍr	"	"	"
Mālik	"	"	"
Quraysh (Fihr)	"	"	"
Ghālib	"	"	"
Lu'ayy	"	"	"
Kaʻab	"	"	"
Murrah	"	"	"
Kilāb	"	"	"
Quṣayy	"	"	"
ʻAbd Manāf	"	"	"
Hāshim	"	"	"
ʻAbdul Muṭṭalib	"	"	"
ʻAbdullāh	"	"	"
MUḤAMMAD			

(See Genesis 25:12-16, and *Muhammad the Holy Prophet* by H. G. Sarwar, pp. 10, 11)

Footnotes

1. Matthew 5:17, 18 in the *New English Bible.*
2. Sura Al-Maida, verses 44-48.
3. Curt Kuhl, *The Old Testament: Its Origin and Composition* (London, 1961), pp. 47, 51, 52.
4. James Hastings, *Dictionary of the Bible* (New York, 1963), pp. 340, 567-569.
5. Genesis 22:16-18, Jewish Publication Society's version, 1955. Note that the son of sacrifice (Dhabīhullāh) is stated to be the *only son* of Abraham. Recent Jewish translations change this to read the "favored son" of Abraham. However, the Hebrew text says *yehideka,* which is a noun form of *yahīd. Yahīd* in Hebrew corresponds with *wahīd* in Arabic and has the same meaning: "sole, single, only, only one." (*Shilo Hebrew Dictionary,* p. 83.). The reference thus must be to Ishmael, not Isaac, since Isaac was never the sole or only son of Abraham. However, some Jewish commentators, while admitting that *yehideka* means "only son," twist the meaning to make it refer to Isaac by saying that Ishmael was illegitimate, so Isaac was the only real son of Abraham. But the Torah of the Bible nowhere says that Ishmael was illegitimate. Rather, it says, "And Sarah Abraham's wife took Hagar her maid, the Egyptian, and gave her to her husband Abraham *to be his wife.*" (Genesis 16:3) Since Hagar became the second WIFE of Abraham, Ishmael could not have been "illegitimate." A man does not bear illegitimate children from his wife! Further, God says of Ishmael, "*I have blessed him* . . . and will make him a great nation." (Genesis 17:20) In Genesis 17:23, 25 and 26, we read: "And Abraham took Ishmael HIS SON . . . and Ishmael HIS SON was thirteen years old, when he was circumcised . . . In the selfsame day was Abraham circumcised, and Ishmael HIS SON." At the very last, when Abraham had passed away, the Bible says: "And his sons Isaac AND ISHMAEL buried him in the cave of Machpelah." (Genesis 25:9) The Bible is explicit that Ishmael was fully the son of Abraham and by no means illegitimate!
6. E. A. Speiser, *Genesis* (New York, 1964), The Anchor Bible, vol. I, pp. 156,157.
7. Genesis 17:4-10, 20.
8. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 626.
9. Deuteronomy 21:15-17, from *The Torah,* Jewish Publication Soceity, 1962.
10. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 47.
11. See Jeremiah 2:10; Ezekiel 27:21; Isaiah 60:7; Song of Solomon 1:5.
12. Isaiah 42:1-6, 11, *New English Bible.*
13. Matthew 15:24.
14. Deuteronomy 18:18, 19.
15. John 14:16, 17.
16. John 16:13, 14. It may be argued that Jesus was speaking for the benefit of his contemporaries, who died at least 500 years before Muhammad (pbuh). But many are the examples in the New Testament wherein Jesus, though speaking with his immediate followers, actually addresses his remarks to different generations in a future time. For example, see Matthew 16:27, 28. Jesus talks about Judgment Day but says: "Verily I say unto you, There be some standing here, which shall not taste of death, till they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom." And at Matthew 24:3, 34, while speaking about the Last Day, he declares, "Verily I say unto you, This generation shall not pass, till all these things be fulfilled" Obviously, *those disciples* with Jesus then did not live to see either Judgment Day or the Second Coming of Jesus, neither of which has even yet occurred. *Jesus' words, though given to his contemporaries, had reference primarily to a time far distant in the future.* When Jesus says "I say unto YOU," he means his followers in the general sense, i.e., "you my people". Jesus is identifying in John 14 and 16 the Last Prophet for the benefit of his followers who would be living when he appeared.
17. Joseph H. Mayfield, *Beacon Bible Commentary* (Kansas City, 1965), vol. VII, p. 168.
18. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 14. Note the striking similarity between the two words *parakletos* and *periklytos* in Greek:

παρακλητος περικλυτος

Footnotes

1. Matthew 5:17, 18 in the *New English Bible.*
2. Sura Al-Maida, verses 44-48.
3. Curt Kuhl, *The Old Testament: Its Origin and Composition* (London, 1961), pp. 47, 51, 52.
4. James Hastings, *Dictionary of the Bible* (New York, 1963), pp. 340, 567-569.
5. Genesis 22:16-18, Jewish Publication Society's version, 1955. Note that the son of sacrifice (Dhabīhullāh) is stated to be the *only son* of Abraham. Recent Jewish translations change this to read the "favored son" of Abraham. However, the Hebrew text says *yehideka,* which is a noun form of *yahīd. Yahīd* in Hebrew corresponds with *wahīd* in Arabic and has the same meaning: "sole, single, only, only one." (*Shilo Hebrew Dictionary,* p. 83.). The reference thus must be to Ishmael, not Isaac, since Isaac was never the sole or only son of Abraham. However, some Jewish commentators, while admitting that *yehideka* means "only son," twist the meaning to make it refer to Isaac by saying that Ishmael was illegitimate, so Isaac was the only real son of Abraham. But the Torah of the Bible nowhere says that Ishmael was illegitimate. Rather, it says, "And Sarah Abraham's wife took Hagar her maid, the Egyptian, and gave her to her husband Abraham *to be his wife.*" (Genesis 16:3) Since Hagar became the second WIFE of Abraham, Ishmael could not have been "illegitimate." A man does not bear illegitimate children from his wife! Further, God says of Ishmael, "*I have blessed him* . . . and will make him a great nation." (Genesis 17:20) In Genesis 17:23, 25 and 26, we read: "And Abraham took Ishmael HIS SON . . . and Ishmael HIS SON was thirteen years old, when he was circumcised . . . In the selfsame day was Abraham circumcised, and Ishmael HIS SON." At the very last, when Abraham had passed away, the Bible says: "And his sons Isaac AND ISHMAEL buried him in the cave of Machpelah." (Genesis 25:9) The Bible is explicit that Ishmael was fully the son of Abraham and by no means illegitimate!
6. E. A. Speiser, *Genesis* (New York, 1964), The Anchor Bible, vol. I, pp. 156,157.
7. Genesis 17:4-10, 20.
8. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 626.
9. Deuteronomy 21:15-17, from *The Torah*, Jewish Publication Soceity, 1962.
10. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 47.
11. See Jeremiah 2:10; Ezekiel 27:21; Isaiah 60:7; Song of Solomon 1:5.
12. Isaiah 42:1-6, 11, *New English Bible.*
13. Matthew 15:24.
14. Deuteronomy 18:18, 19.
15. John 14:16, 17.
16. John 16:13, 14. It may be argued that Jesus was speaking for the benefit of his contemporaries, who died at least 500 years before Muhammad (pbuh). But many are the examples in the New Testament wherein Jesus, though speaking with his immediate followers, actually addresses his remarks to different generations in a future time. For example, see Matthew 16:27, 28. Jesus talks about Judgment Day but says: "Verily I say unto you, There be some standing here, which shall not taste of death, till they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom." And at Matthew 24:3, 34, while speaking about the Last Day, he declares, "Verily I say unto you, This generation shall not pass, till all these things be fulfilled" Obviously, *those disciples* with Jesus then did not live to see either Judgment Day or the Second Coming of Jesus, neither of which has even yet occurred. *Jesus' words, though given to his contemporaries, had reference primarily to a time far distant in the future.* When Jesus says "I say unto YOU," he means his followers in the general sense, i.e., "you my people". Jesus is identifying in John 14 and 16 the Last Prophet for the benefit of his followers who would be living when he appeared.
17. Joseph H. Mayfield, *Beacon Bible Commentary* (Kansas City, 1965), vol. VII, p. 168.
18. Hastings, *op. cit.*, p. 14. Note the striking similarity between the two words *parakletos* and *periklytos* in Greek:

παρακλητος περικλυτος

by Pope Shenūda III
Pope of Alexandria and St. Mark's Diocese

The Qur'an and Christianity

While there are points of disagreement, Christianity is treated fairly in the Qur'an. The Virgin Mary and Jesus Christ are honored and revered, belief in the Gospel as preached by Christ is enjoined upon every Muslim, and the true followers of previous scriptures are counted among the righteous. In this article, the Patriarch of the Coptic Orthodox Church conveys to the readers of Islam his personal understanding of the Qur'an's treatment of Christianity.

This subject is so vast that many volumes of books have been written on it. Therefore, I cannot claim here that all the essential points will be covered in just a few pages. However, I will attempt to present a number of specific points which I believe the readers may be interested in. As for details, they should be left for specialized researchers.

The Qur'an discusses Christianity in many suras. It explains that Christianity represented a divinely-inspired religion, originated by God Almighty for the guidance of, and as a mercy for, mankind. It was presented to man through Jesus Christ, the son of Mary. The Qur'an states that the believers among the Christians will receive their recompense from their Lord. The Christians are clearly distinguished from the polytheists as well as from the pagans. The Qur'an considers the Christians closest to the Muslims in friendship, due to their humbleness and piety.

Jesus Christ is treated in the Qur'an with great reverence and respect. He is described as "a word from God" and a "spirit from Him". His virgin birth is recognized as a unique miracle never achieved by any other human. He died and was raised to heaven in a miraculous manner which puzzled the scholars and theologians throughout the history. He lived on earth preaching and guiding the people. The miracles he performed included some never performed by any man. The scripture he preached, Al-Injīl (the Gospel) is recognized as divine.

The Gospel occupies a prominent position in the Qur'an. Thus, the Qur'an "confirms" the Gospel, and requires its adherents to believe in it.

The Qur'an does not mention anywhere that it came to "replace" the Gospel or the Torah. On the contrary, it states that the faith of the believers is not complete unless they uphold and honor the Torah and the Gospel.

The Virgin Mary, Christ's mother, is held in a position of great respect. Her piety, purity, and righteousness are repeatedly hailed by the Qur'an. God endowed her with a special status, by selecting her to rank over and above all other women.

The Qur'an also deals with the disciples of Christ in a most kind way. It also deals with certain beliefs which are erroneously attributed by some to Christianity, and it is here that certain points of disagreement may arise. While there are points of disagreement, I will show that some of these arose from misunderstanding the basic doctrines of Christianity. In fact, careful examination of some misunderstood points will show that the Qur'an and Christianity are in full agreement as far as these points are concerned.

The Christians in the Qur'an

The Qur'an calls them "The People of the Book", or "The People of the Scripture", or "those who were given the scripture before you," or "The Christians". The Qur'an describes them as believers, worshipers of God, and righteous people. Thus, verses 113-114 of sura Āli-'Imrān (No. 3) states,

لَيْسُوا۟ سَوَآءً ۗ مِّنْ أَهْلِ ٱلْكِتَٰبِ أُمَّةٌ قَآئِمَةٌ
يَتْلُونَ ءَايَٰتِ ٱللَّهِ ءَانَآءَ ٱلَّيْلِ وَهُمْ يَسْجُدُونَ ﴿١١٣﴾ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِٱللَّهِ وَٱلْيَوْمِ
ٱلْءَاخِرِ وَيَأْمُرُونَ بِٱلْمَعْرُوفِ وَيَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ ٱلْمُنكَرِ وَيُسَٰرِعُونَ فِى ٱلْخَيْرَٰتِ ۖ
وَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مِنَ ٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ ﴿١١٤﴾

Among the people of the scripture there are some who are righteous. They recite the revelations of God throughout the night, as they fall prostrate (to God). They believe in God and the last day (the day of judgement), and they enjoin righteousness and prohibit evil. And they hasten into good deeds. They are among the pious.

In sura Baqarah, verse 121 states,

ٱلَّذِينَ
ءَاتَيْنَٰهُمُ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ يَتْلُونَهُۥ حَقَّ تِلَاوَتِهِۦٓ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِهِۦ ۗ وَمَن
يَكْفُرْ بِهِۦ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ هُمُ ٱلْخَٰسِرُونَ ﴿١٢١﴾

***Those who received the scripture, and truly understand it, shall believe therein* (2:121).**

In sura Al-Nisā' we read,

وَلَقَدْ وَصَّيْنَا ٱلَّذِينَ أُوتُوا۟ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ وَإِيَّاكُمْ أَنِ ٱتَّقُوا۟ ٱللَّهَ

We have enjoined those who were given the scripture before you, what We enjoin upon you; that you shall observe piety towards God (4:131).

The Christians, therefore, are considered among the righteous. They worship God, and they fall prostrate before Him as they recite His revelations. They believe in God and the last day, and they are pious. For these reasons, the Qur'an enjoins its followers to debate with the Christians courteously. Thus, sura Al-'Ankabūt (29:46) states,

وَلَا تُجَٰدِلُوٓا۟ أَهْلَ
ٱلْكِتَٰبِ إِلَّا بِٱلَّتِى هِىَ أَحْسَنُ إِلَّا ٱلَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا۟ مِنْهُمْ ۖ وَقُولُوٓا۟ ءَامَنَّا بِٱلَّذِىٓ
أُنزِلَ إِلَيْنَا وَأُنزِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ وَإِلَٰهُنَا وَإِلَٰهُكُمْ وَٰحِدٌ وَنَحْنُ لَهُۥ مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿٤٦﴾

You shall not argue with the people of the scripture but in a courteous manner, excepting the unjust among them. You shall say, "We believe in what was sent down to us, as well as what was sent down to you. Our God and your God is one (and the same). To Him we are submitting (Muslims)".

The Qur'an did not stop at advocating courtesy when debating the Christians, it even placed the Christians in a position of counsel for the new Muslims in matters of religion. In sura Yūnus (10:94), it states,

فَإِن كُنتَ فِى شَكٍّ مِّمَّآ أَنزَلْنَآ إِلَيْكَ فَسْـَٔلِ ٱلَّذِينَ
يَقْرَءُونَ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ مِن قَبْلِكَ ۚ لَقَدْ جَآءَكَ ٱلْحَقُّ مِن رَّبِّكَ فَلَا تَكُونَنَّ
مِنَ ٱلْمُمْتَرِينَ ﴿٩٤﴾

If you (O Muḥammad) have any doubts in matters regarding the scripture which is being revealed to you, you may ask those who have knowledge of previous scriptures.

And in sura Al-Anbiā' (21:7) we read,

وَمَآ أَرْسَلْنَا قَبْلَكَ إِلَّا رِجَالًا
نُّوحِىٓ إِلَيْهِمْ ۖ فَسْـَٔلُوٓا۟ أَهْلَ ٱلذِّكْرِ إِن كُنتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٧﴾

We have sent before you (O Muḥammad) but men whom We have inspired. Therefore, you (O believers) shall ask those who have knowledge of the scripture, if you lack the knowledge.

The Qur'an describes the Christians as people of love and mercy. In sura Al-Ḥadīd (57:27) we read,

ثُمَّ قَفَّيْنَا عَلَىٰ آثَارِهِم بِرُسُلِنَا وَقَفَّيْنَا بِعِيسَى ابْنِ مَرْيَمَ
وَآتَيْنَاهُ الْإِنجِيلَ وَجَعَلْنَا فِي قُلُوبِ الَّذِينَ اتَّبَعُوهُ رَأْفَةً وَرَحْمَةً
وَرَهْبَانِيَّةً ابْتَدَعُوهَا مَا كَتَبْنَاهَا عَلَيْهِمْ إِلَّا ابْتِغَاءَ رِضْوَانِ اللَّهِ
فَمَا رَعَوْهَا حَقَّ رِعَايَتِهَا فَآتَيْنَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مِنْهُمْ أَجْرَهُمْ وَكَثِيرٌ مِّنْهُمْ
فَاسِقُونَ ﴿٢٧﴾

Subsequently, We sent Jesus, the son of Mary, and We revealed to him the Gospel. And We placed love and mercy in the hearts of his followers.

The Qur'an states that the Christians are the closest to the Muslims in friendship and brotherhood. This is mentioned in sura Al-Mā-idah (5:82),

لَتَجِدَنَّ أَشَدَّ النَّاسِ عَدَاوَةً لِّلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا الْيَهُودَ وَالَّذِينَ أَشْرَكُوا وَلَتَجِدَنَّ
أَقْرَبَهُم مَّوَدَّةً لِّلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا الَّذِينَ قَالُوا إِنَّا نَصَارَىٰ ذَٰلِكَ بِأَنَّ مِنْهُمْ قِسِّيسِينَ
وَرُهْبَانًا وَأَنَّهُمْ لَا يَسْتَكْبِرُونَ ﴿٨٢﴾

You will find the most ardent enemies of the believers to be the Jews and the Polytheists. And you will find that the closest in friendship to the believers are those who say, "We are Christian." That, because among them are priests and monks, and because they are not arrogant.

We observe in this verse a distinct separation between the Christians and the polytheists. For the verse mentions three different groups; the Jews and the polytheists on the one side, and the Christians on the other. Thus, if the Qur'an considered the Christians to be polytheists, this separation would have not been made. The separation between the Christians and the polytheists is unquestionably clear throughout the Qur'an, and is not limited to the above-mentioned verse. Thus, sura Al-Ḥajj (22:17) states,

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَالَّذِينَ هَادُوا وَالصَّابِئِينَ وَالنَّصَارَىٰ وَالْمَجُوسَ
وَالَّذِينَ أَشْرَكُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَفْصِلُ بَيْنَهُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ
شَهِيدٌ ﴿١٧﴾

Surely, those who believe, those who are Jewish, the Sabians, the Christians, the Magi, and the polytheists, will be judged by God on the day of resurrection. Surely, God witnesses all things.

This same separation occurs in sura Āli-'Imrān (3:186). We also find it prominently in the Islamic laws of mixed marriage, the laws of Jizya (tax), and many other matters which go beyond the scope of this article. In any case, the Qur'an's look at the Christians accurately portrays them as

monotheists, a matter which is often misunderstood by many followers of the Qur'an today. This point will be discussed further towards the end of the article. The Qur'an's tolerant look at the Christians is manifested also in sura Al-Baqara (2:62) and in sura Al-Mā-idah (5:69). In sura Al-Baqara we read,

إِنَّ ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟
وَٱلَّذِينَ هَادُوا۟ وَٱلنَّصَٰرَىٰ وَٱلصَّٰبِـُٔونَ مَنْ ءَامَنَ بِٱللَّهِ وَٱلْيَوْمِ ٱلْـَٔاخِرِ
وَعَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا فَلَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِندَ رَبِّهِمْ وَلَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ
يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Surely, those who believed, those who were Jewish, the Christians, and the Sabians; any among them who truly believed in God and the last day (the day of judgement), and did righteous deeds, will receive their recompense from their Lord, and they shall have no fear, nor shall they grieve.

The Gospel in the Qur'an

As for the Injīl, the Qur'an considers it a holy scripture, revealed from God, and should be recited by each Muslim, Christian, and believer in God. Thus, in verses 3 and 4 of sura Āli-'Imrān, we read,

نَزَّلَ عَلَيْكَ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ
بِٱلْحَقِّ مُصَدِّقًا لِّمَا بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ وَأَنزَلَ ٱلتَّوْرَىٰةَ وَٱلْإِنجِيلَ ﴿٣﴾ مِن قَبْلُ
هُدًى لِّلنَّاسِ وَأَنزَلَ ٱلْفُرْقَانَ ۗ إِنَّ ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا۟ بِـَٔايَٰتِ ٱللَّهِ لَهُمْ عَذَابٌ
شَدِيدٌ ۗ وَٱللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ ذُو ٱنتِقَامٍ ﴿٤﴾

He revealed to you (O Muḥammad) this scripture, bearing the truth, and confirming previous scriptures, just as He revealed the Torah and the Injīl previously for the guidance of mankind **(3:3-4).**

And in sura Al-Mā-idah, we read,

وَقَفَّيْنَا عَلَىٰٓ ءَاثَٰرِهِم بِعِيسَى ٱبْنِ مَرْيَمَ مُصَدِّقًا لِّمَا بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ مِنَ ٱلتَّوْرَىٰةِ ۖ وَءَاتَيْنَٰهُ
ٱلْإِنجِيلَ فِيهِ هُدًى وَنُورٌ وَمُصَدِّقًا لِّمَا بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ مِنَ ٱلتَّوْرَىٰةِ وَهُدًى
وَمَوْعِظَةً لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ ﴿٤٦﴾ وَلْيَحْكُمْ أَهْلُ ٱلْإِنجِيلِ بِمَآ أَنزَلَ ٱللَّهُ فِيهِ ۚ وَمَن
لَّمْ يَحْكُم بِمَآ أَنزَلَ ٱللَّهُ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ هُمُ ٱلْفَٰسِقُونَ ﴿٤٧﴾ وَأَنزَلْنَآ إِلَيْكَ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ
بِٱلْحَقِّ مُصَدِّقًا لِّمَا بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ مِنَ ٱلْكِتَٰبِ وَمُهَيْمِنًا عَلَيْهِ

And subsequent to them, We sent Jesus the son of Mary believing in what was revealed before him of Torah. Then We revealed to him the Injīl containing guidance and light, in confirmation of previous scripture, the Torah, and providing guidelines and admonitions for the pious ones. And to provide the followers of the Injīl with a law to judge therewith. Those who judge not in accordance with God's law are indeed wicked. Then We revealed to you (O Muḥammad) this scripture, bearing the truth, confirming and superseding all previous scriptures **(5:46-48).**

The fact that the Qur'an "confirms" the previous scriptures denotes the validity of the Injīl and the Torah as divine scriptures, for it would be impossible for any Muslim to believe that the Qur'an supports and confirms invalid books. Had the Torah and Injīl been invalidated, the Qur'an would not have enjoined the people of Injīl to "judge therewith." Nor would we see the commandment in sura Al-Mā-idah,

قُلْ يَٰٓأَهْلَ ٱلْكِتَٰبِ لَسْتُمْ عَلَىٰ شَىْءٍ حَتَّىٰ
تُقِيمُوا۟ ٱلتَّوْرَىٰةَ وَٱلْإِنجِيلَ وَمَآ أُنزِلَ إِلَيْكُم مِّن رَّبِّكُمْ ۗ وَلَيَزِيدَنَّ كَثِيرًا
مِّنْهُم مَّآ أُنزِلَ إِلَيْكَ مِن رَّبِّكَ طُغْيَٰنًا وَكُفْرًا ۖ فَلَا تَأْسَ عَلَى ٱلْقَوْمِ ٱلْكَٰفِرِينَ

Say, O people of the book, you shall have no basis unless you uphold the Torah, the Injīl, and what is sent down to you from your Lord.

Frequent indeed are the verses which state that the Qur'an came to confirm previous scriptures. In addition to the above-mentioned verses, we should note verse 136 of sura Al-Nisā',

يَٰٓأَيُّهَا ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوٓا۟ ءَامِنُوا۟ بِٱللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِۦ وَٱلْكِتَٰبِ ٱلَّذِى
نَزَّلَ عَلَىٰ رَسُولِهِۦ وَٱلْكِتَٰبِ ٱلَّذِىٓ أَنزَلَ مِن قَبْلُ ۚ وَمَن يَكْفُرْ بِٱللَّهِ
وَمَلَٰٓئِكَتِهِۦ وَكُتُبِهِۦ وَرُسُلِهِۦ وَٱلْيَوْمِ ٱلْءَاخِرِ فَقَدْ ضَلَّ ضَلَٰلًۢا بَعِيدًا ﴿١٣٦﴾

O you who believe, you shall believe in God, His messenger *(Muḥummad), the scripture revealed to His messenger, as well as the scriptures revealed previously. Whoever disbelieves in God, His angels, His scriptures, His messengers, and the day of judgement, has indeed strayed very far.* **(4:136).**

Note the use of the plural word "scriptures = kutubihi = كتبه" instead of the singular "scripture = kitābihi = كتابه." Therefore, the Qur'an enjoins belief in ALL divine scriptures which were sent as guidelines, light, and admonitions for the pious. The importance of this all-encompassing belief was emphasized in sura Al-Baqara,

وَالَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِمَا أُنزِلَ
إِلَيْكَ وَمَا أُنزِلَ مِن قَبْلِكَ وَبِالْآخِرَةِ هُمْ يُوقِنُونَ ④
أُولَٰئِكَ عَلَىٰ هُدًى مِّن رَّبِّهِمْ ۖ وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ ⑤

And (the true believers) believe in what was sent down to you (O Muḥammad), and what was sent down before you, and about the hereafter they are but certain. They followed the guidance from their Lord, and these are the successful ones. (2:4-5)

Also in suras Al-Baqara and Āli-'Imrān we find statement of the general Qur'anic belief as represented by verse 136 of Al-Baqara,

قُولُوا آمَنَّا
بِاللَّهِ وَمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْنَا وَمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَىٰ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَإِسْمَاعِيلَ وَإِسْحَاقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ
وَالْأَسْبَاطِ وَمَا أُوتِيَ مُوسَىٰ وَعِيسَىٰ وَمَا أُوتِيَ النَّبِيُّونَ مِن رَّبِّهِمْ لَا نُفَرِّقُ
بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِّنْهُمْ وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُسْلِمُونَ ⑬⑥

Say, We believe in God, and in what was sent down to us, and in what was sent down to Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob, and the Patriarchs. And we believe in what was given to Moses and Jesus, and in what was given to all the prophets from their Lord. (2: part of verse 136) (3: part of 84).

It appears from this representative number of verses that the Qur'an does not replace the Torah and/or the Injīl, for it could not be a replacement and at the same time enjoin belief in them. One additional observation; whenever the Qur'an mentions Injīl, it means specifically the Injīl preached by Jesus Christ. No where in the Qur'an does it mention that false gospel known as the "gospel of Barnabas." The name Barnabas does not appear anywhere in the Qur'an. Furthermore, many of the doctrines contained in this "gospel" are clearly contradictory to the teachings of Islam.

Christ in the Qur'an

The Qur'an calls him 'Īsā; a name which resembles the Greek word "Ἰησοῦς". The Hebrew name for Christ is "ישוע" which means "devoted". Christ is mentioned in the Qur'an more than ten times (3:45; 4:157,171,172; 5:17(twice),72(twice),75; 9:30,31). The title, "Al-Masīḥ (The Messiah) has been the subject of study of many mufassirs (Qur'anic commentators) throughout the history of Islam. Thus, it was said to denote "purity from sin." Imam Fakhr Al-Rāzī mentioned a hadīth whose transmitter (Abū

Hurayra) says, "I heard the messenger of God say, 'Whenever a child is born, he is touched by the devil, which makes him cry at the moment of birth. The only exception from this has been Mary and her son.'" (Mishkāt Al-Maṣābīḥ, vol. 1, p. 20) (Bukhārī & Muslim). All this, in addition to subsequent material, indicate the revered position of the Messiah in the Qur'an, as well as in the classic writings of the great Imams. The position of Christ in the Qur'an distinguishes him by the following characteristics:

1. He is called "a word from God" and "a spirit from God". This description is repeated in the Qur'an (3:45; 4:171).

إِذْ قَالَتِ الْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ يَٰمَرْيَمُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُبَشِّرُكِ بِكَلِمَةٍ مِّنْهُ اسْمُهُ الْمَسِيحُ
عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ وَجِيهًا فِي الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَمِنَ الْمُقَرَّبِينَ ﴿٤٥﴾

The angels said to Mary, "God conveys to you good news; a word from Him who shall be the Messiah Jesus, son of Mary. He shall be prominent in this world and in the hereafter. He shall be among those who are close (to Me).

﴿١٧١﴾ يَٰٓأَهْلَ الْكِتَٰبِ لَا تَغْلُوا فِي دِينِكُمْ وَلَا
تَقُولُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ إِلَّا الْحَقَّ ۚ إِنَّمَا الْمَسِيحُ عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ وَكَلِمَتُهُ ۚ
أَلْقَىٰهَآ إِلَىٰ مَرْيَمَ وَرُوحٌ مِّنْهُ ۖ فَـَٔامِنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ ۖ وَلَا تَقُولُوا ثَلَٰثَةٌ ۚ انتَهُوا
خَيْرًا لَّكُمْ ۚ إِنَّمَا اللَّهُ إِلَٰهٌ وَٰحِدٌ ۖ سُبْحَانَهُ أَن يَكُونَ لَهُۥ وَلَدٌ ۘ لَّهُۥ مَا فِي السَّمَٰوَٰتِ
وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ ۗ وَكَفَىٰ بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلًا ﴿١٧١﴾ لَّن يَسْتَنكِفَ الْمَسِيحُ أَن يَكُونَ عَبْدًا

Jesus Christ, the son of Mary, is but a messenger of God, and His word which He conveyed to Mary, and a spirit from Him (4:171)

The expression "a word from God" stirred considerable debate among the various theological scholars. A detailed discussion of their views would go beyond the scope of this article. It is noteworthy though, that this expression is similar to the first verse in the Gospel of John. The word "Kalimah = word" used in that expression is derived from the Greek word "logos" and has deep philosophical, as well as esoteric, meanings. Similarly, the expression "a spirit from Him" has evoked a vast amount of research and debate. Whatever the interpretations might be of these two Qur'anic descriptions of Christ, they clearly indicate the prominence of Jesus Christ in Islam.

2. Not only was Christ described as "a word from God, and a spirit from Him," a description never bestowed on any other human being, but also his birth is described in the Qur'an as miraculous and unique. The virgin birth of Christ is described in sura Maryam (No. 19) and in sura

Āli-'Imrān (No. 3). In addition, we are told in verse 46 of sura 3 that even as an infant, Christ performed unique miracles. Thus, he spoke to the people while still an infant in the crib (3:46).

وَيُكَلِّمُ ٱلنَّاسَ فِى ٱلْمَهْدِ وَكَهْلًا وَمِنَ ٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ ﴿٤٦﴾

3. Christ performed miracles never performed by any human being. In addition to his miracles of healing the leprous, healing the hopelessly blind, and reviving the dead, I would like to point out two special and unique miracles. These are the miracles of creation, and knowledge of the unseen. In sura Āli-'Imrān we see that Jesus says,

﴿٤٩﴾ وَرَسُولًا إِلَىٰ بَنِىٓ إِسْرَٰٓءِيلَ أَنِّى قَدْ جِئْتُكُم بِـَٔايَةٍ مِّن رَّبِّكُمْ أَنِّىٓ أَخْلُقُ لَكُم
مِّنَ ٱلطِّينِ كَهَيْـَٔةِ ٱلطَّيْرِ فَأَنفُخُ فِيهِ فَيَكُونُ طَيْرًۢا بِإِذْنِ ٱللَّهِ ۖ وَأُبْرِئُ
ٱلْأَكْمَهَ وَٱلْأَبْرَصَ وَأُحْىِ ٱلْمَوْتَىٰ بِإِذْنِ ٱللَّهِ ۖ وَأُنَبِّئُكُم بِمَا تَأْكُلُونَ
وَمَا تَدَّخِرُونَ فِى بُيُوتِكُمْ ۚ إِنَّ فِى ذَٰلِكَ لَءَايَةً لَّكُمْ إِن كُنتُم مُّؤْمِنِينَ ﴿٤٩﴾

I can fashion for you a bird from clay, then blow onto it, and it becomes a live bird by God's leave. And I can tell you what you ate, and what you store in your homes. These should be convincing signs for you, if you are to believe. **(3:49)**

This verse calls for deep reflection and contemplation. Why was Christ endowed with these miracles to the exclusion of all other beings? These particular miracles represent known qualities of God Himself. Creation is a quality of God, and so is knowledge of the unseen.

4. Christ died, and was raised to heaven in a unique manner. In sura Āli-'Imrān (no. 3), verse 55, we read,

إِذْ قَالَ
ٱللَّهُ يَٰعِيسَىٰٓ إِنِّى مُتَوَفِّيكَ وَرَافِعُكَ إِلَىَّ وَمُطَهِّرُكَ مِنَ ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا۟
وَجَاعِلُ ٱلَّذِينَ ٱتَّبَعُوكَ فَوْقَ ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوٓا۟ إِلَىٰ يَوْمِ ٱلْقِيَٰمَةِ ۖ ثُمَّ إِلَىَّ
مَرْجِعُكُمْ فَأَحْكُمُ بَيْنَكُمْ فِيمَا كُنتُمْ فِيهِ تَخْتَلِفُونَ ﴿٥٥﴾

God said, "O Jesus, I will terminate your mission, raise you towards Me, deliver you from the disbelievers, and I will make those who follow you higher in rank above those who disbelieve, till the day of resurrection." **(3:55)**

While Christianity believes in the death of Christ, and his rise to heaven, the Qur'an did not specify how Christ was raised, and when this raising took place (i.e., before or after death).

5. Other descriptions of Christ in the Qur'an included that he will be "prominent in this life, as well as in the hereafter." (3:45)

وَجِيهًا فِي الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةِ

The leading mufassirs interpreted this description in painstaking details. Unanimously, they agreed on the revered position of Christ in the Qur'an, and that he will have the power of intercession in the hereafter.

The Virgin Mary in the Qur'an

The Qur'an tells of Mary's dedication to God, even before her birth. Her mother, the wife of 'Imrān, made a vow pledging her unborn infant to God. God accepted the newborn Mary according to verse 37 of sura Āli-'Imrān, "Her Lord accepted her gracefully, and brought her up gracefully."

فَتَقَبَّلَهَا رَبُّهَا بِقَبُولٍ حَسَنٍ وَأَنْبَتَهَا نَبَاتًا حَسَنًا

She grew up in the sanctuary under the care of Zachariah. She was fed with sustenance from heaven;

كُلَّمَا دَخَلَ عَلَيْهَا زَكَرِيَّا
الْمِحْرَابَ وَجَدَ عِنْدَهَا رِزْقًا قَالَ يَا مَرْيَمُ أَنَّى لَكِ هَٰذَا قَالَتْ هُوَ مِنْ عِنْدِ
اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَرْزُقُ مَنْ يَشَاءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسَابٍ ﴿٣٧﴾

Whenever Zachariah entered her sanctuary, he found sustenance therein. He asked "O Mary, where did you get this from?" She said, "It came from God." Surely, God sustains whomever He wills without limits. **(3:37)**

The great position of Mary in the Qur'an is adequately represented in verse 42 of sura Āli-'Imrān;

وَإِذْ قَالَتِ الْمَلَائِكَةُ يَا مَرْيَمُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفَاكِ وَطَهَّرَكِ وَاصْطَفَاكِ عَلَىٰ
نِسَاءِ الْعَالَمِينَ ﴿٤٢﴾

The angels said, "O Mary, God has chosen you, sanctified you, and preferred you over all the women."

Thus, Mary is considered in Islam the greatest woman. The Qur'an described her as a chaste virgin, and a devout worshiper who prostrated herself and bowed down in prayer to God. The readers may refer to suras Āli-'Imrān (No. 3) and sura Maryam (No. 19) for further details.

False Points of Disagr

Certain statements in
thereby erroneous im
pressions include the
consider Mary divine
sense, and that God
1. *Divinity of the Virg*
minds of some pe
5). This verse state

***God will ask, '
worship you and
be to You. How
them that, you
while I know n
secrets."***

Christianity does
to that effect is e
as a "slave of th
slaves of God. C
Mary should be
thermore, Chrisi
besides God, eve
in one God, and
2. *Did God take a*
Christians believ
from the Qur'an

***He is the origi
a son, when H***

False Points of Disagreement

Certain statements in the Qur'an are misunderstood by some people, creating thereby erroneous impressions about Christianity. Examples of these impressions include the notion that the Christians are polytheists, that they consider Mary divine, that they believe in a son of God in the "physical" sense, and that God had a wife.

1. *Divinity of the Virgin Mary:* This erroneous impression was created in the minds of some people on the basis of verse 116 in sura Al-Mā-idah (No. 5). This verse states,

وَإِذْ قَالَ ٱللَّهُ
يَٰعِيسَى ٱبْنَ مَرْيَمَ ءَأَنتَ قُلْتَ لِلنَّاسِ ٱتَّخِذُونِى وَأُمِّىَ إِلَٰهَيْنِ مِن دُونِ ٱللَّهِ ۖ
قَالَ سُبْحَٰنَكَ مَا يَكُونُ لِىٓ أَنْ أَقُولَ مَا لَيْسَ لِى بِحَقٍّ ۚ إِن كُنتُ قُلْتُهُۥ فَقَدْ
عَلِمْتَهُۥ ۚ تَعْلَمُ مَا فِى نَفْسِى وَلَآ أَعْلَمُ مَا فِى نَفْسِكَ ۚ إِنَّكَ أَنتَ عَلَّٰمُ ٱلْغُيُوبِ ﴿١١٦﴾

God will ask, "O Jesus, son of Mary, have you told the people to worship you and your mother instead of God?" He will answer, "Glory be to You. How could I tell them what was not right? Had I told them that, you would have known about it. For You know my secrets, while I know not Your Secrets. Surely, You are fully aware of all secrets."

Christianity does not believe in the divinity of Mary, and any impression to that effect is erroneous. In fact, Mary herself is reported in the Gospel as a "slave of the Lord." (Luke 1:38) Thus, she placed herself with the slaves of God. Consequently, if any group resorts to the deification of Mary should be disowned, and even opposed by the Christians. Furthermore, Chrisitianity would not advocate the worship of anyone else besides God, even if Christ is one of those other gods. Christians believe in one God, and I will discuss this point towards the end of the article.

2. *Did God take a "wife" unto Himself?* The erroneous impression that some Christians believe that God took for Himself a wife resulted probably from the Qur'anic verse 101 of sura Al-An'ām (No. 6). This verse states,

سُبْحَٰنَهُۥ وَتَعَٰلَىٰ عَمَّا يَصِفُونَ ﴿١٠٠﴾ بَدِيعُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ
وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۖ أَنَّىٰ يَكُونُ لَهُۥ وَلَدٌ وَلَمْ تَكُن لَّهُۥ صَٰحِبَةٌ ۖ وَخَلَقَ كُلَّ شَىْءٍ ۖ
وَهُوَ بِكُلِّ شَىْءٍ عَلِيمٌ ﴿١٠١﴾ ذَٰلِكُمُ ٱللَّهُ رَبُّكُمْ ۖ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ ۖ خَٰلِقُ كُلِّ شَىْءٍ

He is the originator of the heavens and the earth. How could He have a son, when He never took unto Himself a wife?

Also, in sura Al-Jinn, we read the verse,

يَهْدِي إِلَى الرُّشْدِ فَآمَنَّا بِهِ ۖ وَلَن نُّشْرِكَ بِرَبِّنَا أَحَدًا ﴿٢﴾ وَأَنَّهُ تَعَالَىٰ جَدُّ
رَبِّنَا مَا اتَّخَذَ صَاحِبَةً وَلَا وَلَدًا ﴿٣﴾

The Almighty God is our Lord. He never took unto Himself a wife, nor a son. **(72:3)**

The fact is that Christianity is in full agreement with the Qur'an regarding this point. Christianity, too, believes that God never took unto Himself a wife. The impression that Christians advocate or teach such belief is an erroneous one. God, glory be to Him, is a spirit high above the wants of physical bodies. The sonship of Christ to God is not at all a physical sonship in the Christian beliefs.

3. *Polytheism:* By correcting the erroneous impressions concerning the divinity of Mary, and the sonship of Jesus to God, we can simultaneously clear the misunderstanding about polytheism. The concept of trinity is one of the most misunderstood Christian doctrines. In spite of the Qur'an's repeated assertions that the Christians and the polytheists are different and separate, some people consider the trinity a form of polytheism. However, Christianity condemns any form of trinity which advocates the worship of more than one God. Christianity rejects polytheism and believes in the oneness of God. It does not believe in three gods, but in one God who has no rivals. The biblical verses which preach the oneness of God are numerous, both in the old testament, and the new testament. Therefore, when the Qur'an states,

وَلَا تَقُولُوا ثَلَاثَةٌ ۚ انتَهُوا
خَيْرًا لَّكُمْ ۚ إِنَّمَا اللَّهُ إِلَٰهٌ وَاحِدٌ ۖ سُبْحَانَهُ أَن يَكُونَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ ۘ لَّهُ مَا فِي السَّمَاوَاتِ
وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ ۗ وَكَفَىٰ بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلًا ﴿١٧١﴾ لَّن يَسْتَنكِفَ الْمَسِيحُ أَن يَكُونَ عَبْدًا

Do not say, "Three," for there is but God, the one God. **(4:171)**

Christianity would agree fully. And when the Qur'an states,

لَقَدْ كَفَرَ الَّذِينَ قَالُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ ثَالِثُ ثَلَاثَةٍ ۘ وَمَا
مِنْ إِلَٰهٍ إِلَّا إِلَٰهٌ وَاحِدٌ ۚ وَإِن لَّمْ يَنتَهُوا عَمَّا يَقُولُونَ لَيَمَسَّنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا مِنْهُمْ
عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ ﴿٧٣﴾

Heathen are those who say, "God is one among three, for there is no god except the one God." **(5:73)"**

Christianity makes the same statement. In these and similar Qur'anic verses, Islam opposes the fabrications which are also opposed by Chris-

tianity. The concept of trinity is totally different. We say in it, "In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, ONE God, Amen." Therefore, God is one divine entity, and He has a mind, and a soul. The three are one. Just like fire; though it is one thing, heat and also light are generated therefrom. The fire, its heat, and its light constitute but one entity. Similarly, man and his mind and his soul constitute but one entity. As for the sonship part of the trinity, it is like the sonship of thought to the mind. The mind begets thought, yet it has no spouse.

Finally, what we discussed in this article does not mean that the Qur'an and Christianity agree on all points. Certainly, there are points of disagreement, and fundamental doctrinal differences. These involve the trinity, the resurrection of Christ, salvation, the divinity of Christ, his crucifixion, the esoteric teachings of the church, and the Qur'an itself. But we wished to limit this article to the points of agreement rather than the points of disagreement.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

يَا أَهْلَ الْكِتَابِ قَدْ جَاءَكُمْ رَسُولُنَا يُبَيِّنُ لَكُمْ
كَثِيرًا مِمَّا كُنْتُمْ تُخْفُونَ مِنَ الْكِتَابِ وَيَعْفُو عَنْ كَثِيرٍ ۚ قَدْ جَاءَكُمْ
مِنَ اللَّهِ نُورٌ وَكِتَابٌ مُبِينٌ ﴿١٥﴾ يَهْدِي بِهِ اللَّهُ مَنِ اتَّبَعَ رِضْوَانَهُ سُبُلَ
السَّلَامِ وَيُخْرِجُهُمْ مِنَ الظُّلُمَاتِ إِلَى النُّورِ بِإِذْنِهِ وَيَهْدِيهِمْ إِلَىٰ
صِرَاطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ ﴿١٦﴾

IN THE NAME OF GOD, THE COMPASSIONATE, THE MERCIFUL

O believers in the scripture (Jews and Christians), My messenger (Muḥammad) has come to you to clarify many contents of the scripture which you have concealed, and to pardon many such deeds. Indeed, a light; a clarifying scripture has come to you from God. With it, God guides those who seek His pleasure to the paths of peace, leads them out of the darkness into the light, and guides them to a straight path. (Qur'an 5:15-16)

by Yūsuf Amīn Wālī, Ph.D.

ISLAM:
Was It Spread by the Sword?

Far from being apologetic, this article states the facts, and addresses the question, "If Islam were spread by the sword, how can we account for the fact that the Muslims in the 'unconquered' lands vastly outnumber their brethren in the Arab world?" Professor Wālī is a board member and treasurer of the Supreme Council of the Muslim Youth Organization, Cairo, Egypt.

A dominant impression upon the students of "Islam," "Comparative Religion," or "Religions of the World," in many academic institutions is all too often that "Islam was spread by the sword." Whether this impression is the result of deliberate prejudice, or due to ignorance, the teachers who convey this distorted "truth" are doing a great disservice to themselves and their students. Ironically, those who rise to "defend" Islam have quite frequently fallen into a trap, inadvertently misrepresenting the truth about Islam themselves. In their zeal and enthusiasm, they often counter the various malicious remarks by those ignorant of Islam with emotional and apologetic articles which effect a devaluation of certain Islamic principles. Thus, they almost invariably overlook the important concept of *jihād* in Islam (striving in the cause of God). They tend to limit the scope of *jihād,* and apologize for every movement thereof that it was in "self-defense."

Since the time of the prophet Muḥammad (peace be upon him) many who opposed him and those who persist in opposing evident truth overlook the fundamental principles of religious belief in Islam. Thus, they overlook the basic Islamic principle that "there shall be no compulsion in religion لَآ إِكْرَاهَ فِى ٱلدِّينِ " (Qur'an 2:256). Within the Islamic society, therefore, every individual must be guaranteed absolute freedom to belive in whatever he chooses. It is instructive to look at the heritage of Islam regarding this matter.

Establishing and maintaining the Islamic system inside as well as outside the Arabian peninsula did make *jihād* inevitable under certain circumstances. The very first Islamic *jihād* outside Arabia illustrates this. During the sixth year of *Hijra* (Islamic calendar), the prophet Muḥammad (peace be upon him) received the first divine command to preach Islam universally; that Islam was intended for all the people, all places, and all times. In obedience to

this command, the Prophet sent messages to the kings, emperors, and rulers in various parts of the world conveying God's universal message. One of the Prophet's emissaries was AlḤarth b. 'Umeir. His mission was to deliver the prophet's message to the Byzantine emperor Heraclius (ruled 610-640 C.E.). When Al-Ḥarth reached the Syrian town of Mu'tah, the emperor's viceroy in Syria, Sharḥabīl b. 'Amr Al-Ghassānī, knew of his mission and killed him before he ever reached the emperor. While all the other emissaries of the Prophet delivered their messages without incident, and returned to Medina peacefully, this cold-blooded murder of Al-Ḥarth triggered the first *jihād* campaign. The events which ensued led eventually to the collapse of the Byzantine empire and the subsequent spread of Islam as far North as Turkey, and as far East as Iraq.

The murder of Al-Ḥarth, the peaceful unarmed emissary of Muḥammad (may God bestow peace and blessings upon him), left the Prophet with two alternatives; either to fail the divine commandment of preaching Islam universally, or to re-dispatch the message to Heraclius, protected this time by military might. When three thousand men volunteered to protect Muḥammad's second message, the Prophet delivered to them an historical farewell speech the highlights of which included the following instructions:

1. If you have to fight, you shall fight in the cause of God against the enemies of God.
2. If you come across monks worshipping God in seclusion, you shall not harm them, or disturb them.
3. You shall not kill non-fighters, such as the women, children, and old men.
4. You shall not cut a tree, destory a building, nor shall you damage crops or properties.

Even when we go back to the very beginning of Muḥammad's mission, we find that the initial command to preach Islam was coupled with a strict advocation of peace. The Prophet (peace be upon him) preached Islam secretly for three years until the command came for him to preach publicly:

وَأَنذِرْ عَشِيرَتَكَ ٱلْأَقْرَبِينَ ﴿٢١٤﴾ وَٱخْفِضْ جَنَاحَكَ لِمَنِ ٱتَّبَعَكَ
مِنَ ٱلْمُؤْمِنِينَ ﴿٢١٥﴾ فَإِنْ عَصَوْكَ فَقُلْ إِنِّى بَرِىٓءٌ مِّمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ ﴿٢١٦﴾

You shall preach to those around you. For the believers, you shall lower your wing (in humbleness). As for those who refuse to believe, you shall tell them, "I disavow your (evil) deeds." **(26:214-216)**

In response the Prophet (peace be upon him) invited the chieftains of Mecca to the home of Al-Arqam where he used to hold his teaching sessions. In that meeting, he delivered the famous speech in which he said:

"All praise is due to God. I praise Him, seek His help, believe in Him, and trust in Him. I hereby bear witness that there is no deity except God; there is none who rivals Him. O children of 'Abdul-Muṭṭalib, O children of 'Abd Manāf, O children of Zuhrah, O children of Tayyim, O children of Makhzūm, O children of Asad, God has commanded me to preach His message to those around me. Let it be known that I can offer you no material gains of this world, nor can I help you in the hereafter. My sole function is to deliver the message to you, and ask you to believe that there is no god except the one God."

With this, a most important page in the history of mankind unfolded, and the call of Islam began, characterized by tolerance, moderation, and a whole new set of moral ethics. From that moment on, the spread of Islam was effected mainly by the high moral character of the religion's adherents. The people of Arabia, and later in other parts of the world, witnessed Islam through the behavior and the personal conduct of Muslims in their daily life. It was predominantly this example of personal conduct rather than the Qur'an alone that brought about the massive spread of Islam. The primary influence was by the Muslims themselves as they observed the Islamic way of life. Once this primary influence was manifested, the onlookers sought out the religion by approaching the Qur'an and the teachings of Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him). A well-known, well-documented, example of this process is the case of 'Umar b. Al-Khaṭṭāb.

In his pagan days, 'Umar was an ardent opponent of the new religion. One can imagine his fury when he learned that his own sister and her husband had adopted Islam. It was the behavior of this couple under 'Umar's severe beating that led to 'Umar's Islam. The patience, tolerance, and steadfastness of his sister and brother-in-law awakened him and aroused his curiosity. Thus, their Islamic conduct in the face of his relentless anger exerted the primary influence in the guidance process. He then asked about the religion, its principles, and the Qur'an. By the time they explained the religion to him, and after he heard portions of the Qur'an, he became convinced that Islam was the religion for him. This example illustrates three important points:

1. It was the newly acquired character of 'Umar's sister and her husband that aroused his interest in the religion.
2. The Qur'an's influence came second to complete the guidance process. 'Umar was overwhelmed by the common sense and beauty of the Qur'an. He ended up begging his victims to take him to Muḥammad.
3. Certainly, a powerful man like 'Umar did not adopt Islam by force or under any kind of threat.

You shall slay (the attackers) whenever you encounter them, and evict them from whence they evicted you. Oppression is even worse than murder. You shall not fight them at the Sacred Mosque, unless they attack you therein. If they attack you, then you may slay them, for this would be a just retirubtion for such disbelievers.

This verse clearly defines *jihād* as a *response;* neither initiated nor provoked. It is self-explanatory; leaving no chance for mutiple interpretation. The statement that "oppression is even worse than murder," shows the degree of respect Islam accords to one's freedom of thought; freedom of religion.

Verse 192 instructs us as to when *jihād* must cease. It states,

فَإِنِ ٱنتَهَوْا۟ فَإِنَّ ٱللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَّحِيمٌ ﴿١٩٢﴾

If (the attackers) refrain (from attacking you), then God is Forgiver, Merciful.

This is in fact in line with, and an affirmation of, the commandment, "You shall not aggress." Once the attackers stop their hostilities, continuing to fight them would be in violation of the Qur'anic commandments.

Verse 193 of sura Al-Baqarah (No. 2) states the other reason for *jihād*, namely, oppression and restriction of religious freedom.

وَقَٰتِلُوهُمْ حَتَّىٰ لَا تَكُونَ فِتْنَةٌ وَيَكُونَ ٱلدِّينُ لِلَّهِ

You shall fight them to halt oppression, and to worship God in complete freedom.

This verse closes with the commandment,

فَإِنِ ٱنتَهَوْا۟ فَلَا عُدْوَٰنَ إِلَّا عَلَى ٱلظَّٰلِمِينَ ﴿١٩٣﴾

If they end the oppression, there shall be no aggression except against the unjust.

Even in self-defense, the counter attack must never exceed the severity of the aggressors' attack. This is clearly enjoined in verse 194,

ٱلشَّهْرُ ٱلْحَرَامُ بِٱلشَّهْرِ ٱلْحَرَامِ
وَٱلْحُرُمَٰتُ قِصَاصٌ ۚ فَمَنِ ٱعْتَدَىٰ عَلَيْكُمْ فَٱعْتَدُوا۟ عَلَيْهِ بِمِثْلِ مَا ٱعْتَدَىٰ
عَلَيْكُمْ ۚ وَٱتَّقُوا۟ ٱللَّهَ وَٱعْلَمُوٓا۟ أَنَّ ٱللَّهَ مَعَ ٱلْمُتَّقِينَ ﴿١٩٤﴾

If they attack you during the Sacred Month, then you may fight during the Sacred Month. Any sacrilege they commit may be met by an equivalent response. Thus, if anyone aggresses against you, your response shall not exceed the extent of his aggression. You shall

maintain piety towards God, and know that God is with those who maintain piety.

The periods of war are governed by Islamic rules which are characterized by tolerance and moderation. Thus, pledges of security to the opposing warriors must be respected. Indeed Islam has transcended the limits of tolerance in regard to the question of security so much so that should a Muslim make a hostile sign to warn an enemy of the impending attack and the latter took it for a sign of peace, it is imperative that full security should be vouchsafed him in accordance with what he understood the sign to mean.

Such is the rule in war-time. The security of the enemy who enters a Muslim country with the object of engaging in trade or business rests entirely in the hands of those in authority. Should a member of the public however give his pledge to an enemy who thereby gains admittance into the country for trade and the latter thinks such pledge is binding, full security should be accorded him and if the Wālī (governor) does not deem it in the interest of the country that such security be given, he had to conduct the enemy back to safety.

Again should an enemy ask for security in order to have an insight into religion and it happens that he finds no satisfaction in Islam, he is to be sent back in full security to his own abode of safety, as ordained by the following verse:

وَإِنْ أَحَدٌ مِّنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ
اسْتَجَارَكَ فَأَجِرْهُ حَتَّىٰ يَسْمَعَ كَلَامَ اللَّهِ ثُمَّ أَبْلِغْهُ مَأْمَنَهُ ۚ ذَٰلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ قَوْمٌ
لَّا يَعْلَمُونَ ۝٦

Should a polytheist come to seek your protection in order to hear the Qur'an recited and acquaint himself with the truth thereof, grant him protection till he has heard it, then give him a safe conduct if he chooses not to profess Islam, to his abode of safety. (9:6)

The pledge of security in Islam is a real one, no mere idle talk. It lays particular stress on the safe custody of the wealth and property of those to whom we are bound by treaty. Should the party to the treaty return to his country and leave behind in the dominion of Islam some trust or debt, it is incumbent upon the Muslim authorities to send such to him. Should he die these should be sent to his heirs, and should they not be known, it should be sent to the head of the deceased's community to dispose of it to the next-of-kin.

The sacredness in which the pledge of security was held in Islam is testified to by the saying of 'Umar b. Al-Khaṭṭāb: "I have been told con-

cerning some of you that on going in pursuit of an infidel warrior who flees to shelter in the mountain and there makes himself unassailable, one of you would shout after him 'fear you not' and as soon as he gets to him he would kill him. By Him in whose hands lies my soul, should I know of any one who has done so I would at once put him to death".

As to those who choose to live under the rule and protection of Islam, they are accorded such rights as warrant their complete freedom and render them a living element closely connected with the other elements of the Muslim nation by bonds of amity, good-will and cooperation. These bonds are referred to in Qur'an and the Ḥadīth as well as in the sayings of the Prophet's companions and the learned men who followed them.

The pledge given to the Zimmis (non-Muslims under the rule of Islam) implies that they should live under Muslim protection enjoying full religious liberty and complete security as regards their own persons, their property and their honour. The following quotation from the pledge of 'Umar b. Al-Khaṭṭāb to the people of Elia is significant: "He gave them the pledge of security for their persons, their property, their churches and all followers of their creed. Their churches are not to be inhabited, diminished in number or revenue or crosses and they are not to be forced to renounce their faith or subjected to any harm".

The rules were made clear concerning the infidels who live with or near the Muslims in harmony and peaceful coexistence.

لَا يَنْهَىٰكُمُ ٱللَّهُ عَنِ ٱلَّذِينَ لَمْ يُقَٰتِلُوكُمْ
فِى ٱلدِّينِ وَلَمْ يُخْرِجُوكُم مِّن دِيَٰرِكُمْ أَن تَبَرُّوهُمْ وَتُقْسِطُوٓا۟ إِلَيْهِمْ ۚ إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ
يُحِبُّ ٱلْمُقْسِطِينَ ﴿٨﴾

God does not forbid you to be charitable and to deal justly with those (of the non-Muslims) who have not waged war against you and have not driven you out of your homes; surely God loves those who are just and equitable. **(60:8)**

This verse clearly urges the maintenance of the law of equity in treating the peaceful sections of the non-Muslim communities. It further points to the merit of being charitable and kind to them.

In expressing this, the negative form of speech was purposely used in the verse as it was meant as an answer to what occurs first to the mind that their profession of a different religion detracts from showing kindness to them and respecting their rights.

The great Amirs of Islam have always followed the injunction enjoined by this verse. They were wont to counsel the viceroys to maintain justice in their provinces and they gave particular mention to the treatment of the

non-Muslim subjects under their rule. Perhaps the best instance we can give in illustration of this is a quotation from a message of 'Umar b. Al-Khaṭṭāb to 'Amr b. Al-'Āṣ, then viceroy of Egypt:

"There live with you non-Muslims who are given the pledge of faith and whom the Prophet (peace be upon him) commended to our care, for thus says the Prophet, 'Whoso unfairly treats a covenantor or imposes too heavy a burden on him, will I be his adversary on the judgment day.' Take heed therefore O 'Amr lest the Prophet becomes your adversary. Whoso contends with him will be overthrown".

Ah authentic Tradition in this connection is the saying of the Prophet (peace be upon him) "Whoso reviles a non-Muslim, will be flogged on the judgment day with lashes of fire".

Consider then the great influence of these rules which appeared in an era dominated by barbarism, injustice, and lawlessness. Armed with these divine principles, and the daily Islamic conduct, the Muslims succeeded in spreading Islam through the world.


بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم
أشداء على الكفار رحماء بينهم تراهم ركعا سجدا يبتغون فضلا من الله ورضوانا
محمد رسول الله
والذين معه


بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم
مثل نوره كمشكاة فيها مصباح المصباح في زجاجة
الله
نور السموات والارض

by Rashād Khalīfa, Ph.D.

English Meanings of the Qur'an : 1

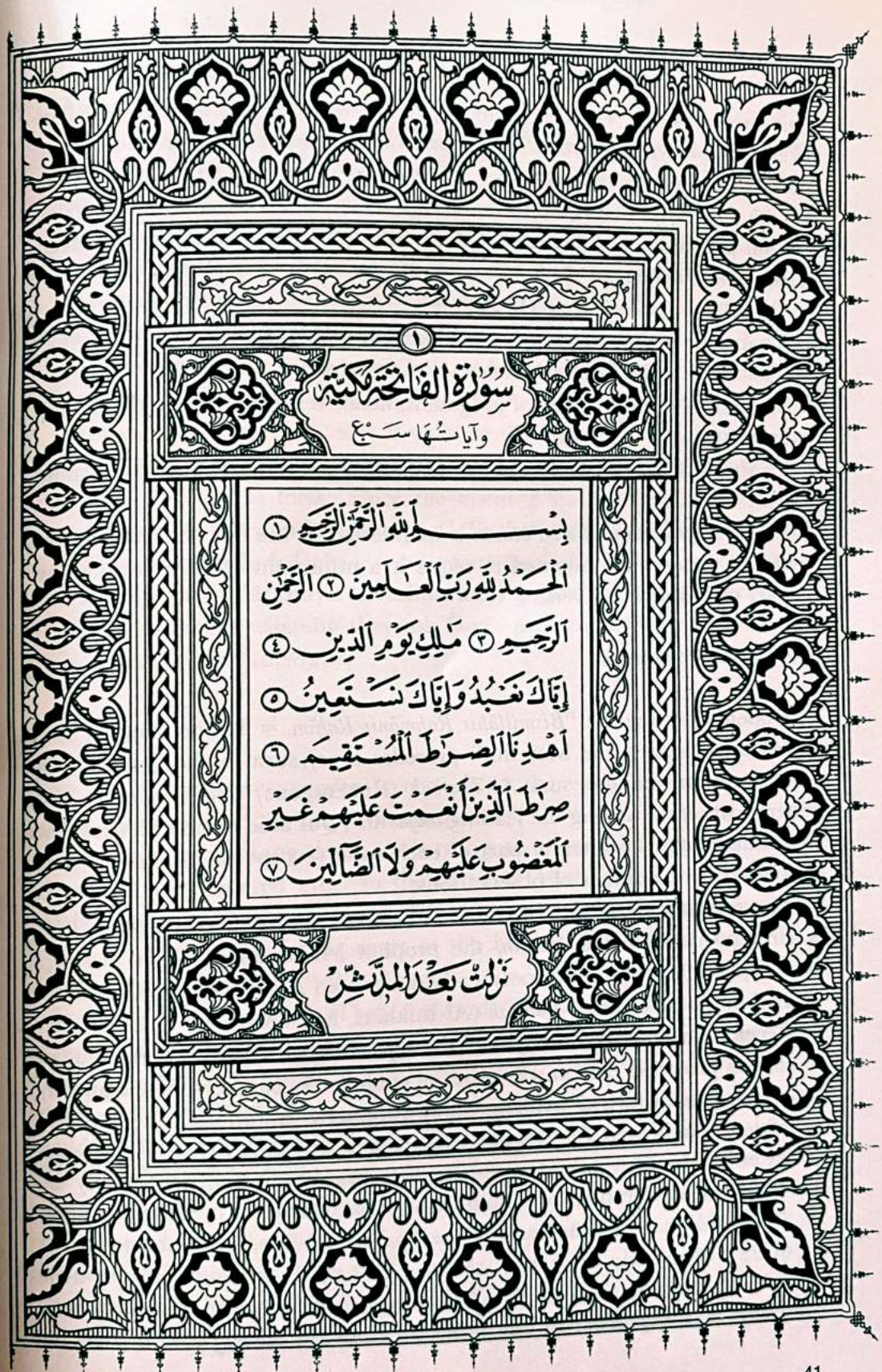
A true understanding of Islam requires, as a minimum, a reasonable understanding of its message, the Qur'an. While many people acquire a distorted picture of the religion by observing some aspects of the actions, history, or personal conduct of its professed followers, the readers of this series are presented with an opportunity to grasp the basic principles of true Islam. Readers who are familiar with the various Qur'anic translations will appreciate the fact that this is the first English rendering of the Qur'an's meanings by a Muslim Arab. It is being printed for the first time.

Sura Al-Fātiḥah (The Opener) 1:1-7

Sura 1
Al-Fātiḥah (The Opener)
REVEALED IN MECCA

1 In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. 2 Praise be to God, the Lord of all beings, 3 The Compassionate, the Merciful, 4 Master of the day of judgment. 5 Only You do we worship, and only You do we implore for help. 6 Guide us along the right path, 7 The path of those upon whom You bestow Your grace; not of those who incur indignation, nor of the strayers.

ISLAM 1394/1974, 1(1): 40-56


١
سورة الفاتحة مكية
وآياتها سبع
بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم ١
الحمد لله رب العالمين ٢ الرحمن
الرحيم ٣ مالك يوم الدين ٤
إياك نعبد وإياك نستعين ٥
اهدنا الصراط المستقيم ٦
صراط الذين أنعمت عليهم غير
المغضوب عليهم ولا الضالين ٧
نزلت بعد المدثر

Furthermore, the word *"Al-Raḥmān"* is an exclusive name of God which equals the name "Allāh" in every respect. Why then should we translate *"Al-Raḥmān,"* and not "Allāh?" The same principle applies to the divine name *"Al-Raḥīm."*

The practice of partially translating *"Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm,"* and using the Arabic (but not necessarily Islamic) word "Allāh" without translation, has led to a number of unfortunate misunderstandings. One such misunderstanding is the impression upon certain people, especially those accustomed to deification of human beings, that "Allāh" is the name of a man. Even highly respectable circles, such as Webster's Dictionaries, were led to believe that "Allāh" is the "Supreme Being of the Muslims" (2). Allāh, of course, is "THE GOD" of all beings, whether they realize it or not.

The Source of Anger

Sura *Al-Fātiḥah,* as the reader realizes, is generally self-explanatory. The last verse, however, has been invariably mistranslated. Thus, most translators, if not all of them, have erroneously identified the source of *"ghaḍab* غَضَبْ," i.e., anger, or wrath, or indignation, to be God Almighty (3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8). The term *"ghayril maghḍūbi 'alayhim* غَيْرِ ٱلْمَغْضُوبِ عَلَيْهِمْ," however, does not identify the source of anger. The source of anger or indignation incurred by the sinners could be God, the angels, or the people. Whatever the case may be, the source of anger is *NOT* identified in sura *Al-Fātiḥah.* Putting this fact in perspective may be significant for those who wish to study the question, **"Is anger a quality of God?"**

chance of coincidence highly unlikely, and confirms that the opening statement is not exogenous to the divine revelation.

3. Aside from the observations on the first and the last suras, one sura in the middle of the Qur'an deliberately omits the opening statement "In the name of God . . ." As mentioned above, this one sura is *Al-Tawbah* (No. 9).

While *"Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm"* is the first verse of Al-Fātiḥah, it is not assigned a specific number in the other suras. In the humble opinion of this commentator, the opening statement, "In the name of God," takes on the number of any verse wherever we start a Qur'anic recitation. Thus, when we recite any sura, with the exception of *Al-Tawbah* (No. 9), the opening statement, "In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful," becomes part of the first verse if we start the recitation at the beginning of the sura; it becomes part of verse number 15 if we start the recitation at verse 15, and so forth. Since the opening statement is shown to be an integral part of each sura (except *Al-Tawbah*), this discussion emphasizes that is must be included whenever we recite the Qur'an. When the recitation is not part of a ṣalāt prayer, Muslims are enjoined to begin the recitation with a statement whereby they ask God's protection from the influence of Satan (Qur'an 16:98).

God vs. Allāh

Some translators have apparently considered the word "Allah" to be *the* proper name of God in Islam. Consequently, they did not translate this "name" into other languages. According to them, the opening words *"Bismillāh"* are rendered into "in the name of Allah." However, the word "Allāh" is not *THE* Islamic name of God, as erroneously believed by some. It is merely the Arabic counterpart of the English words "the God." The syllable *"Al"* in the word "Allāh" means "the." A god or a deity is called *"ilāh"* in the Arabic language. Thus, the words "the God" would be equivalent to the Arabic *"Al-ilāh,"* which is rather awkward phonetically. To overcome this awkwardness, the Arabs simply dropped the letter "i" from *"Al-ilāh,"* which made it "Allāh". The literal translation of the word "Allāh," therefore, would be "The God". Support for the statement that "Allah" is not necessarily *THE* Islamic name of God comes from the fact that all Arabs use this word, regardless of their religion, to mean God. Additionally, the word "Allāh" has been used in pre-Islamic Arabia. The Prophet's father, for example, was named "'Abdullāh (servant of God)."

Translating *"Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm"* into "In the name of Allāh, the Compassionate, the Merciful" constitutes an incomplete translation.

COMMENTARY

This sura, properly entitled "The Opener," was the first sura revealed in its entirety. It was described by the prophet Muḥammad (may God bestow blessings and peace upon him) as "the essence of the Qur'an = *ummul Kitāb* = أُمُّ الْكِتَابِ." This description can be appreciated if we recount the major Islamic principles which are stated in this short sura. Thus, in the seven verses of *Al-Fātiḥah* we are told:

1. To believe in God; that He is One.
2. That God is characterized by compassion and mercy.
3. That God is the Lord, cherisher, and sustainer of all beings.
4. That there shall be a day of judgment, hence resurrection and the eternal hereafter.
5. That only God deserves to be worshiped; He alone is capable of helping us.

The importance of *Al-Fātiḥah* is manifested in the fact that all Muslim men and women are enjoined to recite it a minimum of 17 times per day as part of the ṣalāt prayers.

The Opening Statement

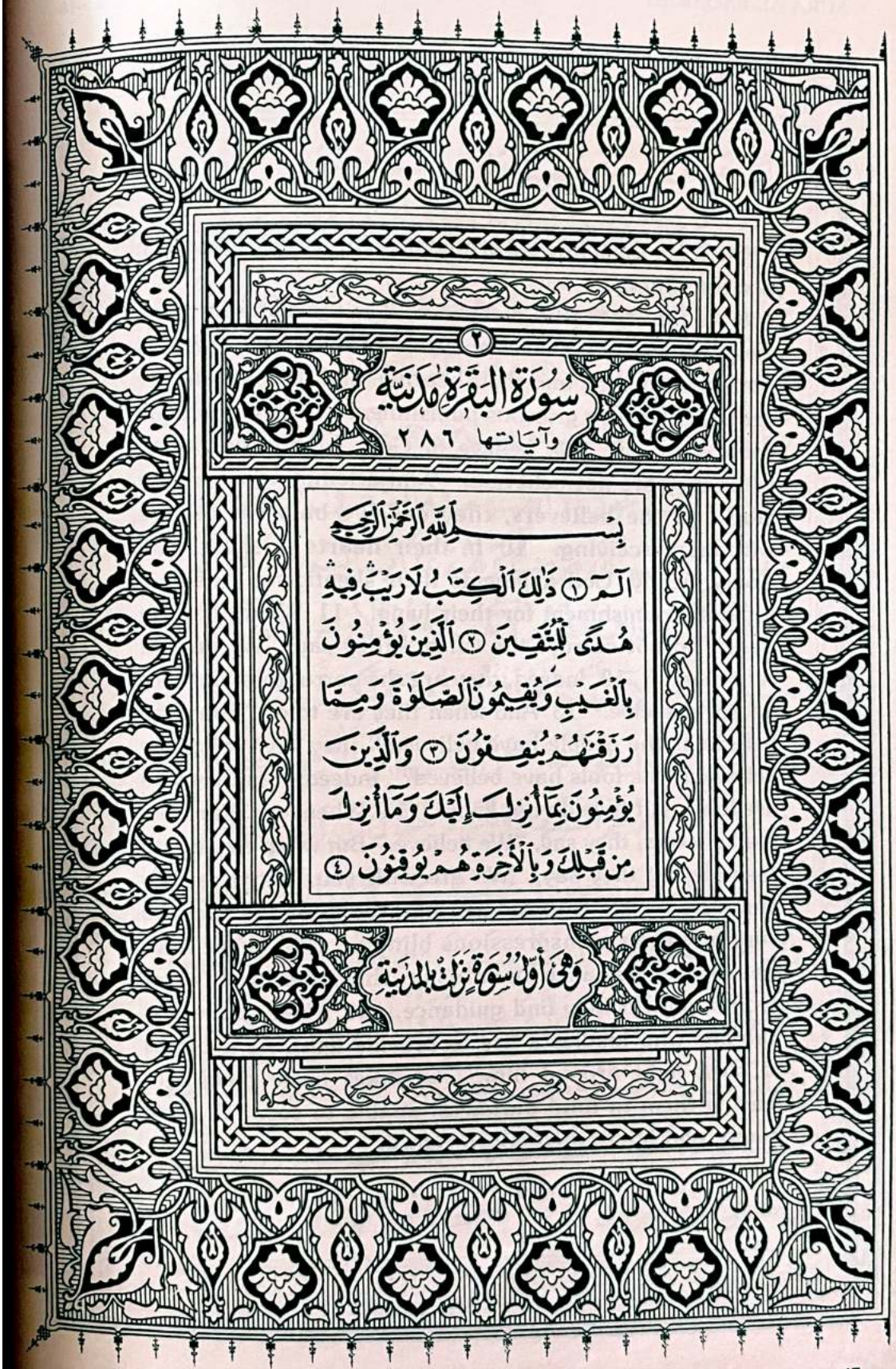
The opening statement *"Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm* = In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful" precedes every sura in the Qur'an with one exception, namely, sura *Al-Tawbah* (Repentance) (No. 9). There is a general consensus among the leading *mufassirs* (Qur'anic commentators) that this statement is an integral part of each sura (except *Al-Tawbah*). This is supported by a number of observations:

1. The opening statement constitutes the first verse of the first sura. In a strongly documented *Ḥadīth,* the prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) specifically designated *Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm* as the first verse of Al-Fātiḥah (Al-Bukhārī, Muslim).
2. Recent computerized analysis of the alphabetical structure of the Qur'an (1) has provided new and conclusive evidence to supplement the already convincing historical evidence and prophetic traditions. The physical evidence indicated by the computerized study shows clearly that each letter in the Qur'an's composition was accurately and deliberately calculated. For example, computed without excluding the opening statement *"Bismillāh . . ."* the final sura of the Qur'an, Al-Nās, was found to consist of 99 alphabetic letters — the same number as God's ninety-nine magnificent names. The fact that this particular number of alphabetic letters does not occur in any other sura but the closing sura renders the

Sura Al-Baqarah (The Heifer) 2:1-29

Sura 2
Al-Baqarah (The Heifer)
REVEALED IN MEDINA

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful
1 A.L.M. 2 This scripture is without a doubt; providing guidance for the righteous, 3 Who believe in the unseen, observe the *ṣalāt* prayers, and from My provisions to them they spend. 4 They believe in what was sent down to you (O Muḥammad), and in what was sent down before you, and they firmly believe in the hereafter.


٢
سورة البقرة مدنية
وآياتها ٢٨٦
بسم الله الرحمن الرحيم
الم ١ ذلك الكتب لا ريب فيه
هدى للمتقين ٢ الذين يؤمنون
بالغيب ويقيمون الصلوة ومما
رزقنهم ينفقون ٣ والذين
يؤمنون بما أنزل إليك وما أنزل
من قبلك وبالأخرة هم يوقنون ٤
وهي أول سورة نزلت بالمدنية

5 Such are the followers of guidance from their Lord. Such are the winners.

6 As for those who disbelieve, it is the same for them; whether you warn them or not, they do not believe. 7 God seals their hearts, and their hearing, and their visions are veiled. Theirs is a grievous punishment. 8 And there are those who say, "We believe in God and the hereafter," while they are not believers. 9 In attempting to deceive God and the believers, they deceive only themselves, without perceiving. 10 In their hearts is skepticism. Consequently, God augments their skepticism. Theirs is a painful punishment for their lying. 11 When they are told, "Do not corrupt the earth," they say, "We are but reformers." 12 Indeed, they are the corruptors, but they do not perceive. 13 And when they are told, "You shall believe as the people have believed," they say, "Shall we believe as the fools have believed?" Indeed, it is they who are fools, but they do not know. 14 Whenever they meet the believers, they say, "We believe." But when alone with their devils, they say, "We are with you. We were only mocking." 15 God mocks them by allowing them to continue their transgressions blindly. 16 These have traded away guidance for straying. Thus, their trade never profits, nor do they find guidance. 17 Their allegory is like one who kindles a fire to provide light. As it begins to shed light around him, God takes away their light, leaving them in total darkness, unable to see. 18 Deaf, dumb, and blind; they fail to reform.




الجزء الأول
(٢) سورة البقرة
أُولَٰئِكَ عَلَىٰ هُدًى مِّن رَّبِّهِمْ ۖ وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ ۝٥ إِنَّ الَّذِينَ
كَفَرُوا سَوَاءٌ عَلَيْهِمْ أَأَنذَرْتَهُمْ أَمْ لَمْ تُنذِرْهُمْ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ ۝٦
خَتَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَىٰ قُلُوبِهِمْ وَعَلَىٰ سَمْعِهِمْ ۖ وَعَلَىٰ أَبْصَارِهِمْ غِشَاوَةٌ ۖ
وَلَهُمْ عَذَابٌ عَظِيمٌ ۝٧ وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَن يَقُولُ آمَنَّا بِاللَّهِ
وَبِالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَمَا هُم بِمُؤْمِنِينَ ۝٨ يُخَادِعُونَ اللَّهَ وَالَّذِينَ
آمَنُوا وَمَا يَخْدَعُونَ إِلَّا أَنفُسَهُمْ وَمَا يَشْعُرُونَ ۝٩ فِي قُلُوبِهِم
مَّرَضٌ فَزَادَهُمُ اللَّهُ مَرَضًا ۖ وَلَهُمْ عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ بِمَا كَانُوا
يَكْذِبُونَ ۝١٠ وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمْ لَا تُفْسِدُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ قَالُوا إِنَّمَا نَحْنُ
مُصْلِحُونَ ۝١١ أَلَا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ الْمُفْسِدُونَ وَلَٰكِن لَّا يَشْعُرُونَ ۝١٢
وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمْ آمِنُوا كَمَا آمَنَ النَّاسُ قَالُوا أَنُؤْمِنُ كَمَا آمَنَ
السُّفَهَاءُ ۗ أَلَا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ السُّفَهَاءُ وَلَٰكِن لَّا يَعْلَمُونَ ۝١٣ وَإِذَا لَقُوا الَّذِينَ
آمَنُوا قَالُوا آمَنَّا وَإِذَا خَلَوْا إِلَىٰ شَيَاطِينِهِمْ قَالُوا إِنَّا مَعَكُمْ
إِنَّمَا نَحْنُ مُسْتَهْزِئُونَ ۝١٤ اللَّهُ يَسْتَهْزِئُ بِهِمْ وَيَمُدُّهُمْ فِي طُغْيَانِهِمْ
يَعْمَهُونَ ۝١٥ أُولَٰئِكَ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرَوُا الضَّلَالَةَ بِالْهُدَىٰ
فَمَا رَبِحَت تِّجَارَتُهُمْ وَمَا كَانُوا مُهْتَدِينَ ۝١٦ مَثَلُهُمْ كَمَثَلِ الَّذِي
اسْتَوْقَدَ نَارًا فَلَمَّا أَضَاءَتْ مَا حَوْلَهُ ذَهَبَ اللَّهُ بِنُورِهِمْ وَتَرَكَهُمْ
فِي ظُلُمَاتٍ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ ۝١٧ صُمٌّ بُكْمٌ عُمْيٌ فَهُمْ لَا يَرْجِعُونَ ۝١٨
٤

19 Or, like a storm from the sky, with darkness, thunder, and lightning. They place their fingers in their ears, as if to evade death by the thunder bolts. God thus encompasses the disbelievers. 20 The lightning intermittently snatches away their eyesight. Whenever it lights for them, they walk therein. And when it turns dark, they stand still. If God wills, He can deprive them of their hearing, and their sight. Surely, God is Omnipotent.

21 O mankind, you shall worship your Lord, who created you, and those before you, that you may be devout. 22 It is He Who rendered the earth habitable for you, and He rendered the sky a structure. He sends down water from the sky to produce fruits for your sustenance. Therefore, you shall not set up rivals to rank with God, despite this knowledge. 23 If you have any doubts concerning what We have revealed herein to our servant (Muḥammad), then produce one sura like these, and invite your idols, whom you worship instead of God, to do the same, if you are right. 24 If you fail to do this, and most certainly you shall fail, then beware of the hellfire whose fuel shall be people and rocks. It awaits the disbelievers. 25 As for those who believe, and do good works, give them the good news that they shall enjoy Gardens with flowing streams. Whenever they are provided with fruits therein, they shall say, "This was provided for us previously." They shall be given similar provisions, and they shall have pure spouses therein. They shall abide therein eternally. 26 Thus, God is not ashamed to cite any kind of allegory, from as lowly as a mosquito, and higher. As for those who believe, they shall know that it is the truth from their Lord. As for those who disbelieve, they shall say, "What did God mean by such an allegory ?" Thus, He misleads many thereby, and He guides many thereby. But he never misleads any thereby except the wicked.

أَوْ كَصَيِّبٍ مِّنَ ٱلسَّمَآءِ فِيهِ ظُلُمَٰتٌ وَرَعْدٌ وَبَرْقٌ يَجْعَلُونَ أَصَٰبِعَهُمْ
فِىٓ ءَاذَانِهِم مِّنَ ٱلصَّوَٰعِقِ حَذَرَ ٱلْمَوْتِ ۚ وَٱللَّهُ مُحِيطٌۢ بِٱلْكَٰفِرِينَ ﴿١٩﴾
يَكَادُ ٱلْبَرْقُ يَخْطَفُ أَبْصَٰرَهُمْ ۖ كُلَّمَآ أَضَآءَ لَهُم مَّشَوْا فِيهِ وَإِذَآ
أَظْلَمَ عَلَيْهِمْ قَامُوا ۚ وَلَوْ شَآءَ ٱللَّهُ لَذَهَبَ بِسَمْعِهِمْ وَأَبْصَٰرِهِمْ ۚ إِنَّ
ٱللَّهَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَىْءٍ قَدِيرٌ ﴿٢٠﴾ يَٰٓأَيُّهَا ٱلنَّاسُ ٱعْبُدُوا۟ رَبَّكُمُ ٱلَّذِى
خَلَقَكُمْ وَٱلَّذِينَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ ﴿٢١﴾ ٱلَّذِى جَعَلَ لَكُمُ
ٱلْأَرْضَ فِرَٰشًا وَٱلسَّمَآءَ بِنَآءً وَأَنزَلَ مِنَ ٱلسَّمَآءِ مَآءً فَأَخْرَجَ بِهِۦ مِنَ
ٱلثَّمَرَٰتِ رِزْقًا لَّكُمْ ۖ فَلَا تَجْعَلُوا۟ لِلَّهِ أَندَادًا وَأَنتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٢٢﴾ وَإِن
كُنتُمْ فِى رَيْبٍ مِّمَّا نَزَّلْنَا عَلَىٰ عَبْدِنَا فَأْتُوا۟ بِسُورَةٍ مِّن مِّثْلِهِۦ وَٱدْعُوا۟
شُهَدَآءَكُم مِّن دُونِ ٱللَّهِ إِن كُنتُمْ صَٰدِقِينَ ﴿٢٣﴾ فَإِن لَّمْ تَفْعَلُوا۟ وَلَن تَفْعَلُوا۟
فَٱتَّقُوا۟ ٱلنَّارَ ٱلَّتِى وَقُودُهَا ٱلنَّاسُ وَٱلْحِجَارَةُ ۖ أُعِدَّتْ لِلْكَٰفِرِينَ ﴿٢٤﴾ وَبَشِّرِ
ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟ وَعَمِلُوا۟ ٱلصَّٰلِحَٰتِ أَنَّ لَهُمْ جَنَّٰتٍ تَجْرِى مِن تَحْتِهَا ٱلْأَنْهَٰرُ ۖ
كُلَّمَا رُزِقُوا۟ مِنْهَا مِن ثَمَرَةٍ رِّزْقًا قَالُوا۟ هَٰذَا ٱلَّذِى رُزِقْنَا مِن قَبْلُ ۖ وَأُتُوا۟
بِهِۦ مُتَشَٰبِهًا ۖ وَلَهُمْ فِيهَآ أَزْوَٰجٌ مُّطَهَّرَةٌ ۖ وَهُمْ فِيهَا خَٰلِدُونَ ﴿٢٥﴾
* إِنَّ ٱللَّهَ لَا يَسْتَحْىِۦٓ أَن يَضْرِبَ مَثَلًا مَّا بَعُوضَةً فَمَا فَوْقَهَا ۚ فَأَمَّا ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟
فَيَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ ٱلْحَقُّ مِن رَّبِّهِمْ ۖ وَأَمَّا ٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا۟ فَيَقُولُونَ مَاذَآ أَرَادَ ٱللَّهُ بِهَٰذَا
مَثَلًا ۘ يُضِلُّ بِهِۦ كَثِيرًا وَيَهْدِى بِهِۦ كَثِيرًا ۚ وَمَا يُضِلُّ بِهِۦٓ إِلَّا ٱلْفَٰسِقِينَ ﴿٢٦﴾

27 (The wicked ones) who break their covenant with God after accepting it, tear asunder what God had commanded to preserve, and corrupt the earth. Such are the losers. 28 How can you disbelieve in God? You were dead, and He granted you life; then He will put you to death; then He will bring you back to life; then to Him you shall be returned. 29 It is He who created for you everything on earth. Then He turned to the sky and fashioned seven heavens therein. He is Omniscient.

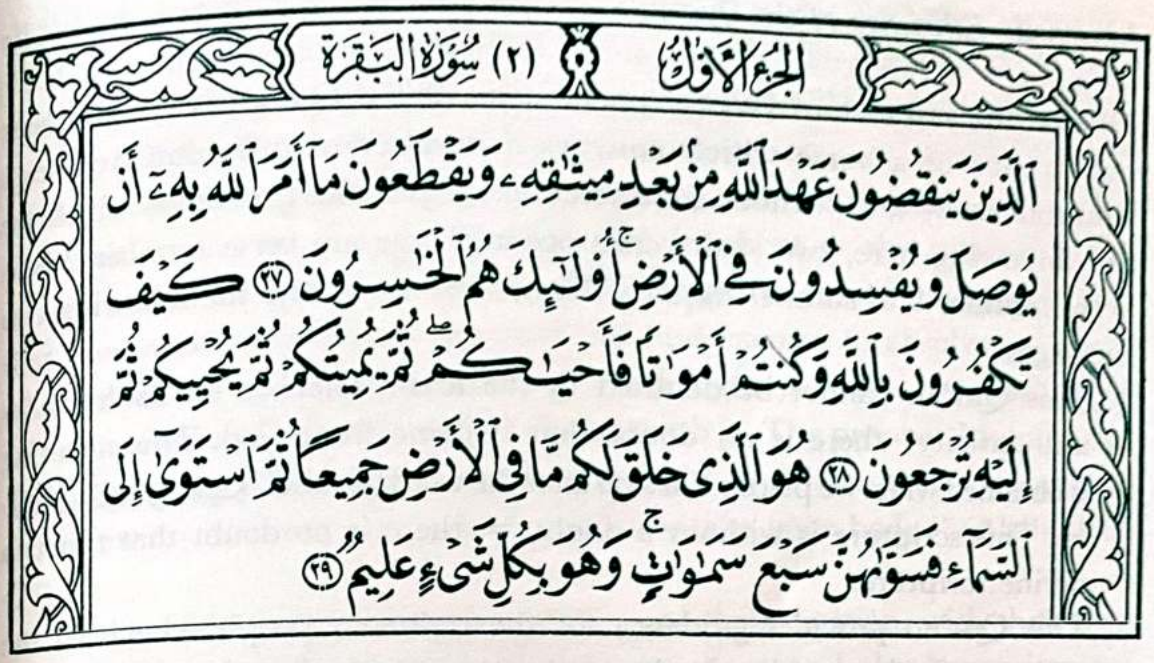
COMMENTARY

Sura Al-Baqarah was the first sura revealed in Medina. Its title, which means the heifer, refers to a very siginificant incident which is reported in verses 67-74; an incident wherein Moses proved to the Israelites that he did communicate with God; an incident wherein a murder victim was revived to point out his murderer, and thus a great sign was manifested to the Children of Israel. A distorted version of this incident appears in today's bibles. (Numbers 19:6)

The Letters A.L.M.:

The first verse of sura *Al-Baqarah* consists of three independent letters of the Arabic alphabet, namely, *Alif* (A), *Lām* (L), and *Mīm* (M). Throughout the Qur'an, there are 29 suras which are prefixed with such "initials." These Qur'anic initials are known as "openers of the suras فَوَاتِحُ السُّوَرِ;" in the Western literature, they are called "the mysterious letters." The possible significance of these letters has been the subject of numerous theories in the past 14 centuries. There is a unanimous agreement in the literature that the significance of the Qur'anic initials has never been unveiled (3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12).

In the course of preparing this commentary, however, the Qur'anic initials were studied extensively with the help of electronic computers. By the grace of God, the possible role of the Qur'anic initials was at least partially uncovered. The data, the results, and the conclusions were so vast that they



required an independent book (1). Thus, for a detailed study of the Qur'anic initials, the reader may refer to reference No. 1. This computerized study of the Qur'anic initials provided undisputable evidence that the Qur'an is the word of God; that it could never be written by a man, or any number of men, in the past, present, or future.

Since we are concerned here with the three Qur'anic initials *Alif* (A), *Lām* (L), and *Mīm* (M) of sura *Al-Baqarah,* the specific function of these letters is presented herein. It appeared from the detailed computerized study that the letters A.L.M. provide mathematical support for the system of recording the Qur'an (1). The frequency of occurrence of these 3 letters throughout the Qur'an indicates that the final form of Qur'an as we know it today is the divinely ordained form. Thus, it was found that the suras which contain these initials [Al-Baqarah (No. 2), Āli-'Imrān (No. 3), Al-'Ankabūt (No. 29), Al-Rūm (No. 30), Luqmān (No. 31), and Al-Sajdah (No. 32)] were required to be averaged together according to their continuity in the Qur'an, regardless of their revelation sequence, in order to observe their superiority with regard to the frequency of A, L, & M. It should be noted that the A.L.M.-initialed suras were revealed separately, but recorded consecutively. The opposite was true with regard to the letters A.L.R.; the A.L.R.-initialed suras were revealed consecutively, but recorded separately. The computerized study showed that while the Qur'anic initials A.L.M. serve to confirm the recorded sequence of Qur'an, the initials A.L.R. serve to confirm the authenticity of the revelation sequence. The indulgence of the reader is requested for presenting this extremely condensed explanation of the Qur'anic initials. For a full understanding of this discussion the reader may refer to the detailed study.

Linguistic Efficiency of the Qur'an

One of the miraculous literary phenomena of the Qur'an is the frequent occurrence of a verse which conveys a number of different meanings, simultaneously and without contradiction. In just the few verses which we are discussing here, two such verses occur. These are verse number 2 and verse number 7 of sura *Al-Baqarah*. Thus, verse 2 conveys the following two messages:

1. This Qur'an cannot be doubted in the least. There is no doubt in its authenticity; there is no doubt that it came from God. This meaning is obtained when we place a full stop after the word "doubt" ذَٰلِكَ ٱلْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيهِ = This scripture is without a doubt = there is no doubt that this is a divine scripture.
2. This Qur'an provides guidance for the righteous people who heed the message. Such meaning is obtained as we recite the same verse to the end, " ذَٰلِكَ ٱلْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ ... فِيهِ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ this scripture is without a doubt; providing guidance for the righteous."

The reader will note that the English rendering was done in such a way to convey, as closely as possible, the same impression as that conveyed by the Arabic text upon the Arabic reader.

Similarly, we can simultaneously derive two compatible meanings from verse 7:

1. God seals the hearts of the disbelievers, and places *a veil on their hearing and their vision.*
2. God *seals the hearts and the hearing* of the disbelievers, and places a veil upon their vision.

This linguistic efficiency is unique to the Qur'an; it explains to us the deliberate omission of the punctuation marks therefrom.

Three Types of People:

Verses 3 through 20 of sura Al-Baqarah divide the people into three categories; the righteous, the heathens, and the hypocrites. It is significant that the righteous are described in three verses; the heathens are described in two verses, while the hypocrites are described in 13 verses. These facts reflect the subtleness of hypocrisy and the need to recognize it, especially within ourselves, and expose it.

Since the criteria are set so clearly and vividly in the Qur'an, no further comment is needed regarding the three categories of people. One can read the divine verses, and directly use them to find his place within these three categories. Thus, I cannot count myself among the righteous unless I fulfill

all the requirements set forth in verses 3 and 4, namely, belief in the unseen (God, the angels, the hereafter, etc), observing the five daily ṣalāt prayers, spending from God's provision (not hoarding), belief in and upholding the Qur'an, belief in and upholding all previous revelations, and certainty about resurrection. Unless I fulfill these six requirements, I will have to find my place within the other two categories, the heathens or the hypocrites. As we seek to find our place among these three categories, it is of vital importance that one must never defend his "self" or find excuses to absolve it. Those who do achieve salvation and discover the right *path* are those who can courageously accuse the self and never side with it. The prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) said in this respect, "Your most ardent enemy is your 'self' which resides within your body." (Al-Bukhārī) (13).

It should be noted that as a *consequence* of their decision, with their own free will, to reject God's guidance, the heathens and the hypocrites are rendered totally deaf, dumb, and blind to any divine admonition (verses 6, 7, 10, & 18). Thus, there is no way whereby anyone can convince them of the most obvious truths.

Moreover, verses 10 and 26 of sura Al-Baqarah (as well as numerous verses throughout the Qur'an) explicitly inform us that the rejectors of truth are actually led further and further from the truth by none other than the Almighty Himself. After exercising their absolute freedom, and after reaching a decision to reject God's truth, such rejectors are placed under circumstances which serve invariably to move them away from the right path. This fact is especially evident in the writings of the anti-Islam activists; one can see so clearly that they are always led into a maze of dead-end alleys where they remain hopelessly trapped.

In verses 21 and 22, mankind is enjoined to worship the Creator; Who created them and provided for them. As for the skeptics who refuse to give serious, objective thought to God's message, the Qur'an, they are handed a challenge to prove their claim that it is man-made. The challenge (verse 23) is coupled with an assurance that no one can possibly meet it (verse 24). The recent computerized study of the Qur'an, which provided physical evidence that the Qur'an could never be man-made, sheds a new light on the Qur'anic challenge explained here. By physical, examinable means, it is now proven that the miraculous composition of the Qur'an is not only literal, but also mathematical. For the reader who is not yet familiar with the computerized study of the Qur'an's alphabetical structure, let us take a simple example. Among the Qur'an's 114 suras, two are initialed with the letter *Qāf* (Q). These two suras are *Al-Shūrā* (No. 42) and *Qāf* (No. 50). Although sura *Al-Shūrā* is more than twice as long as sura *Qāf*, the

computer revealed that these two suras contain the same number of the letter *Qāf* (Q), namely 57 each. Considering that the Qur'an was revealed over a period of 23 years, and that the individual verses came down widely separated both in time and place, it becomes undeniably clear that the Qur'an is the word of God. No creature could ever possess advance knowledge of the mathematical distribution of the individual alphabetic letters throughout the Qur'an. This overwhelming evidence is physical, touchable, and examinable, since anyone anywhere in the world can count the letter *Qāf* in the two Qāf-initialed suras and find for himself or herself that they contain the same numbers of *Qāfs,* 57. Obviously, this number is not random. When we add the 57 *Qāfs* of sura Al-Shūrā to the 57 *Qāfs* of sura *Qāf,* we get 114, same number as the suras of Qur'an. Thus, if the letter "Q" stands for "Qur'an," the inescapable message is clear; that the 114 suras constitute God's message to humanity, the whole message, and nothing but the message.

This very small and very simple example from the computerized study of Qur'an is consistent with the divine statement in verse 24 regarding the impossiblity of composing anything like the Qur'an by other than God Himself.

We come across the first description of heaven and hell in verses 24 and 25. Verse 24 describes hell as a fire whose fuel shall be people and rocks. Verse 25 describes heaven as gardens with flowing streams, fruits, and pure spouses. At the same time, we are told in verse 26 that these are allegorical descriptions; that heaven and hell are described in the Qur'an in terms we can comprehend; terms which the simplest, illiterate individuals, as well as the most educated ones, can appreciate and understand. The Prophet Muḥammad (may God bestow blessings and peace upon him) reiterated the spirit of verse 26 when he told us that heaven is something "no eye has ever seen, no ear has ever heard, and never imagined by a human being."

References

1. Khalīfa, R. 1973. *Miracle of the Qur'an: Significance of the Mysterious Alphabets.* Islamic Productions International, Inc., Box 12202, St. Louis, Mo. 63157.
2. *Webster's Seventh New Collegiate Dictionary.* 1965. G. & C. Merriam Co., Springfield, Mass. p. 23.
3. Sale, George. 1883. *The Koran.* John B. Alden, New York. p. 13.
4. Pickthall, M. M. 1961. *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran.* The New American Library, New York. p. 31.
5. Arberry, A. J. 1970. *The Koran Interpreted.* The MacMillian Co., New York. p. 29.
6. Dawood, N. J. 1970. *The Koran.* Penguin Books, Baltimore, Maryland. p. 15.
7. Maududi, S. A. A. 1971. *The Meaning of the Qur'an.* Islamic Publications Ltd. Lahore, Pakistan. p. 32.
8. Jeffrey, Arthur. 1958. *The Koran.* The Heritage Press, New York. p. 23.
9. Ali, A. Y. 1968. *The Holy Qur'an.* Dar Al-Arabia, Box 6089, Beirut, Lebanon. p. 17.
10. Wajdī, M. F. 1969. *Al-Muṣ-ḥaf Al-Mufassir.* Dar Al-Sha'b, Cairo, Egypt. p. 3.
11. Al-Jalālain. 1925. *Tafsīr Al-Qur'an Al-'Aẓīm.* Al-Taqaddum Al-'Ilmiyyah Press, Cairo, Egypt. p. 2.
12. Al-Baydāwī. 1960. *Tafsīr Al-Qur'an Al-Karīm.* Al-Jumhūriyyah Al-Miṣriyyah Bookstore, Cairo, Egypt. p. 5.
13. Al-Ghazālī, (Imām) M. 1898. *Ihyā' 'Ulūm Al-Dīn.* Vol. 3. Al-Azhariyyah Al-Miṣriyyah Press, Cairo, Egypt. p. 143.

by Professor M. Farīd Wajdī

ISLAM: Its Mission in the World

1. UNITY OF RELIGIOUS BELIEF

Of all his achievements as writer, editor of Nour-el-Islam, *and Professor at Al-Azhar University, Dr. Wajdī is better known for his famous Qur'anic commentary. This series of articles, which were written by him in Arabic, promises to be a most cherished feature by ALL readers of* Islam.

One of the great human aspects which lends immortality to Islam and establishes for it an historical right to intercourse with all people, is the inculcation of religious unity in so far as the source of religions is one and the same. The plurality and difference of religions were due to the addition, deletion and corruption which took place in the first and original faith.

This notion of religious unity would have been regarded as an intellectual impossibility were it conceived in the olden days on account of the fundamental differences which existed between religions. Indeed, it is still regarded by the sociologists of today who are unacquainted with Islam, as a far-off hope because of the intermingling of religions with national and racial affairs.

The efforts they made were therefore to exclude all religions from the field of human activities and to counteract its effect in society so that humanity may attain the universal peace and understanding for which it strives with nothing to obstruct its way.

Yet, should those who study human affairs contemplate the principles on which Islam has established this unity and the historical facts on which it has relied, they would soon realize that these principles are by far more effectual than all the means employed by them. The beneficial effect of those principles had been amply shown in the uniting of nations in the early days of Islam despite the great influence which racial distinctions have had over their minds at the time. But these distinctions are fast disappearing today so much so that they have come to be regarded as purely theoretical. This has been due to the spread of philosophic and scientific ideas among nations, and to return today to Islam's principle of uniting them on a religious basis, would have more effect than it ever had before on the primitive nations which were devoid of all intellectual enlightenment.

ISLAM 1394/1974, 1(1): 57-62

Here someone may contend that the civilized nations of today do not depend on religion for their ascendancy or progress and even though we granted that they answered the call of Islam and adopted one religion, they have the economic problems which may overwhelm them and bring them into conflict. What advantage would the call to unity of religion avail so long as nations remain subject to social and economic factors?

We should say Yes! But does not our critic agree that these nations have come to realize that war is an abominable means to settle differences and that it weakens both victor and vanquished alike particularly when their interests in the economic field have become so intricate that the least trouble that upsets the one is bound to affect the other, and that for this reason they are looking for an effectual means to abolish it once and for all? If to these world-wide efforts the inculcation of the idea of one religion be added, would it not be to the good of the world? Would it not contribute to the unity of nations and help to overcome the destructive forces of disunion?

Let us now consider the principles on which Islam has founded the unity of religious belief and the historical facts on which it has relied to render this idea acceptable to the minds:

1. Islam has proclaimed that the religion of God is one and the same for all times, that it was revealed to the first apostle sent to mankind and that the Lord has continued its revelation to His apostles from time to time of the world history to renew the signs which have been obliterated, elucidate its principles and rectify the corruption which took place. In this connection the Lord says:

شَرَعَ لَكُم مِّنَ الدِّينِ مَا وَصَّىٰ بِهِ نُوحًا وَالَّذِي أَوْحَيْنَا إِلَيْكَ
وَمَا وَصَّيْنَا بِهِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَمُوسَىٰ وَعِيسَىٰ أَنْ أَقِيمُوا الدِّينَ وَلَا تَتَفَرَّقُوا
فِيهِ كَبُرَ عَلَى الْمُشْرِكِينَ مَا تَدْعُوهُمْ إِلَيْهِ اللَّهُ يَجْتَبِي إِلَيْهِ مَن يَشَاءُ
وَيَهْدِي إِلَيْهِ مَن يُنِيبُ ﴿١٣﴾

God has ordained to you the religion which He commanded unto Noah, and which I revealed to thee and which I commanded unto Abraham, Moses and Jesus: Observe thou this religion by true belief and obedience, and divide not into sects concerning it. The worship of one God to which thou callest them is intolerable unto the disbelievers. God will choose to that Faith whomsoever he pleaseth, and will guide thereunto whomsoever shall turn unto Him (42:13).

2. Religion is a divine instinct which the Lord has implanted in human nature and no human soul is devoid thereof. In this respect it is undeniably a natural instinct and the Lord says:

فَأَقِمْ وَجْهَكَ لِلدِّينِ حَنِيفًا ۚ فِطْرَتَ اللَّهِ الَّتِي فَطَرَ النَّاسَ
عَلَيْهَا ۚ لَا تَبْدِيلَ لِخَلْقِ اللَّهِ ۚ ذَٰلِكَ الدِّينُ الْقَيِّمُ وَلَٰكِنَّ أَكْثَرَ النَّاسِ لَا
يَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٣٠﴾

Wherefore set thou thy face towards the true Faith deviating not therefrom: the law of God to which men are created and are naturally disposed. No one could change the creation of God. This is the true Faith but the greater part of men know it not (30:30).

3. Islam has established pure reason to be a guiding beacon in all differences in the light of divine revelation.
4. The cause of all differences in religion which leads to division therein, is the tendency to iniquity, disregard of reason and blind imitation. In this connection the Lord says:

وَمَا تَفَرَّقُوا إِلَّا مِن بَعْدِ مَا جَاءَهُمُ الْعِلْمُ بَغْيًا بَيْنَهُمْ

Nor were the past generations divided among themselves, through enmity and mutual jealousy, till after the knowledge of truth had come to them (42:14).

The Lord also says:

وَقَالُوا لَوْ كُنَّا نَسْمَعُ أَوْ نَعْقِلُ مَا كُنَّا فِي أَصْحَابِ السَّعِيرِ ﴿١٠﴾

And they shall say, "If we had but hearkened to the discourse of the apostles or had rightly considered it, we should not have been among the dwellers of burning fire" (67:10).

And:

وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمُ اتَّبِعُوا مَا أَنزَلَ
اللَّهُ قَالُوا بَلْ نَتَّبِعُ مَا أَلْفَيْنَا عَلَيْهِ آبَاءَنَا ۗ أَوَلَوْ كَانَ آبَاؤُهُمْ لَا يَعْقِلُونَ
شَيْئًا وَلَا يَهْتَدُونَ ﴿١٧٠﴾

And when it is said unto the believers, "Follow ye what the Lord has sent down," they say, "Nay, but we will follow only that which our fathers practiced." What! will they do so even though their fathers were utterly ignorant and were not guided to the truth? (2:170).

5. Islam which God had revealed to the seal of His prophets Muḥammad (on whom be peace) was the first and initial Faith with which the Lord had sent him to mankind in its entirety to announce unto them these facts and to settle the differences which their passions have provoked. In this connection the Lord says:

إِنَّ ٱلدِّينَ عِندَ ٱللَّهِ ٱلْإِسْلَٰمُ ۗ وَمَا ٱخْتَلَفَ ٱلَّذِينَ
أُوتُوا۟ ٱلْكِتَٰبَ إِلَّا مِنۢ بَعْدِ مَا جَآءَهُمُ ٱلْعِلْمُ بَغْيًۢا بَيْنَهُمْ ۗ وَمَن يَكْفُرْ
بِـَٔايَٰتِ ٱللَّهِ فَإِنَّ ٱللَّهَ سَرِيعُ ٱلْحِسَابِ ﴿١٩﴾

Verily the true Religion with God is submission to Him (Islam) and none other is acceptable unto Him; and those who were given the Scriptures differed not concerning it until after the knowledge of its truth had come to them, through mutual jealousy and desire for supremacy; and whomsoever believeth not in the signs of God, verily God is prompt in reckoning with him (3:19).

And:

أَفَغَيْرَ دِينِ ٱللَّهِ يَبْغُونَ وَلَهُۥٓ أَسْلَمَ مَن فِى ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ
وَٱلْأَرْضِ طَوْعًا وَكَرْهًا وَإِلَيْهِ يُرْجَعُونَ ﴿٨٣﴾

Do the unbelievers seek a religion other than God's, and to Him had everyone in heavens and earth submitted, willingly or unwillingly, and unto Him shall they return? (3:83).

In order to give this religious unity the highest consideration in the minds of men, it was included in the Qur'an in a purposely detailed verse so that no doubt may assail it:

قُولُوٓا۟ ءَامَنَّا
بِٱللَّهِ وَمَآ أُنزِلَ إِلَيْنَا وَمَآ أُنزِلَ إِلَىٰٓ إِبْرَٰهِـۧمَ وَإِسْمَٰعِيلَ وَإِسْحَٰقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ
وَٱلْأَسْبَاطِ وَمَآ أُوتِىَ مُوسَىٰ وَعِيسَىٰ وَمَآ أُوتِىَ ٱلنَّبِيُّونَ مِن رَّبِّهِمْ لَا نُفَرِّقُ
بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِّنْهُمْ وَنَحْنُ لَهُۥ مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿١٣٦﴾ فَإِنْ ءَامَنُوا۟ بِمِثْلِ مَآ ءَامَنتُم بِهِۦ فَقَدِ
ٱهْتَدَوا۟ ۖ وَإِن تَوَلَّوْا۟ فَإِنَّمَا هُمْ فِى شِقَاقٍ ۖ فَسَيَكْفِيكَهُمُ ٱللَّهُ ۚ وَهُوَ
ٱلسَّمِيعُ ٱلْعَلِيمُ ﴿١٣٧﴾ صِبْغَةَ ٱللَّهِ ۖ وَمَنْ أَحْسَنُ مِنَ ٱللَّهِ صِبْغَةً ۖ وَنَحْنُ لَهُۥ
عَٰبِدُونَ ﴿١٣٨﴾

Say ye believers: We believe in God and that which has been sent down to us, and that which has been sent down to Abraham and Ismael and Isaac and Jacob and his offsprings, and that which was given to Moses and Jesus and that which was given to the Prophets from their Lord. We make no distinction between any of them and unto God we are resigned. If therefore they believe in what ye believe, then they are rightly guided; but if they turn away from the true faith, then they are divided among themselves and God will suffice to protect you against them, for He is the Hearer, the Knower. The

law of God to which we are created, there is no better law than His! And Him do we worship (2:136-138).

These principles which show the source of religions to be one, are readily admitted by reason on mere contemplation for they are among its primary axioms.

As to the source of religions being one in all times, no other fact could be more acceptable to reason, for truth is one and could never be more.

As to religion being a divine institution identical with the natural instincts, it is a fact that admits of no doubt for souls are prone to seek the truth and submit to its judgment so long as they are guided by the light of pure reason.

As to the tendency to iniquity, disregard of reason and blind imitation of the practices of ancestors being the cause of differences which divide people among themselves, it is a fact that no one could gainsay and is well borne out by history.

Should man rid himself of all these imperfections and appeal to reason in his search after true religion he will certainly come to Islam. The adoption of these principles in the present day has become within reach of everyone. The spread of learning among the different classes of people and the independent thinking and formulation of personal opinion inspired by wide reading have paved the way for the adoption of these Islamic principles. But they should be presented to people in a form well-worthy of the greatness of the ideals inculcated by them.

And now that Islam has allied itself with reason and science which rests on no hypothesis or conjecture, nothing stands between it and the far-flung dominion anticipated for it, save the organization of the proper introduction and the expounding of its universal principles in every language. Once this is done, no power on earth could stand in its way or stem its tide.

Indeed, the religious beliefs of nations have become so interwoven with their national life that they constitute a principal element of that life. Many nations still hold to these beliefs to maintain their national existence though they no longer believe in them. But through the succession of events which gave rise to a spirit of friendly co-operation between nations and confirmed the belief that their safety lies in mutual understanding, nationalism is losing ground day by day. Further, the economic crises brought about by trade competition have indicated to nations the necessity of setting up a universal system for agricultural and industrial production so that the world may be spared the economic dearth which induce nations to war in the same way as their early ancestors did. This method has not only become abominable, but it has also proved detrimental, for the economic relations between nations

based on the modern business system are so greatly affected by war that the victor so often loses the fruits of his so called victory by the great losses in souls which may exceed those of the vanquished nation itself. It has now become evident that economic depressions affect all nations, victors or vanquished alike.

These considerations have induced the nations of today to seek fresh means of life commensurate with the present changes and the degree of cultural progress which science has brought about in every sphere of life. The efforts are calculated to save humanity from the dangerous passes that may take her back to the early days of barbarism.

Every advocate of unity today brings to the tortured humanity a new remedy with which to heal its wounds. The call to unity is everywhere received with general approval though the beliefs of men have become an elemental part of nationalism in every country. But nationalism has been badly shaken and human communities have felt the need to reorder their time-worn systems to conform with their present and future requirements. We find today nations of different creeds and religions concluding defensive offensive alliances, a thing which could not have taken place up to the last century. The French had risen against their king Francis I for having sought the aid of the Turks against Charles V Emperor of Germany and Austria who threatened to occupy their country in the sixteenth century.

The present day disregard of these considerations is a new departure in international relations and affords ample evidence to the impending overthrow of the barriers that once separated nations.

All this and the like is fast paving the way for the golden age promised by Islam to humanity. It rests with Muslims to make public the great principles inculcated by the Qur'an and draw the attention to the study of Islam so that it may become known unto the whole world.

سَنُرِيهِمْ آيَاتِنَا فِي الْآفَاقِ وَفِي أَنْفُسِهِمْ حَتَّىٰ يَتَبَيَّنَ لَهُمْ أَنَّهُ الْحَقُّ
أَوَلَمْ يَكْفِ بِرَبِّكَ أَنَّهُ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ شَهِيدٌ ﴿٥٣﴾

We will show the unbelievers Our signs in distant climes, and through the wonders wrought in the creation of man till it becomes manifest unto them that the Qur'an is the truth. Doth it not suffice that thy Lord is witness over all things? (41:53).

أَفَغَيْرَ دِينِ اللَّهِ يَبْغُونَ وَلَهُ أَسْلَمَ مَنْ فِي السَّمَاوَاتِ
وَالْأَرْضِ طَوْعًا وَكَرْهًا وَإِلَيْهِ يُرْجَعُونَ ﴿٨٣﴾

Do the unbelievers seek a religion other than God's and to Him had everyone in heavens and earth submitted willingly or unwillingly, and unto Him shall they return? (3:83).

Islamic Concentrates

The Aphorisms of Salāmah Al-Rāḍī : 1

These aphorisms, with their esoteric connotations, are derived from the Qur'an, the sunna, teachings of the great imams, and the principles of Sufism. Published for the first time in English, these particular aphorisms are valuable pieces of advice delivered by one of the greatest Sufis of all time, Shaykh Salāmah Al-Rāḍī, to his dervishes.

INTRODUCTION



This journal takes special pleasure in introducing to the West for the first time a Sufi teacher of the twentieth century. Though loved and followed by many thousands across the Muslim World, Shaykh Salāmah Al-Rāḍī is still virtually unknown to most Western scholars. One profound exception is the renowned French philosopher Rene'Guenon. Not only did Guenon acquaint himself with Shaykh Salāmah, he was actually initiated into the

ISLAM 1394/1974, 1(1): 63-66

mainstream of Sufism as one of the faithful dervishes of Al-Rāḍī. Prior to his initiation, of course, Guenon became a Muslim; he changed his name to 'Abdul-Wāḥid Yaḥyā, married and lived in Egypt until he died in 1370 AH (1951 C.E.).

Shaykh Salāmah Al-Rāḍī was born in Egypt 1293 (1867) and received his general education in the public schools. Thus, like most Sufi teachers, he did not receive his religious education through formal religious schools. Upon completion of his education, Shaykh Salāmah obtained a position with the Egyptian government as an accountant. He remained in this position until his retirement in 1355 (1927) as Chief of the Government's Properties Section, Gīza Province Administration.

Shaykh Al-Rāḍī belonged to the modern Sufi school of 'Ali b. 'Abdullāh Al-Shādhilī, better known as Abul-Ḥasan Al-Shādhilī. This particular school of Sufism advocates not only full participation in this life, but also transforming the daily worldly affairs into a form of worship. Through this series of aphorisms, the readers will gain a better insight into the life and thoughts of this great Sufi leader.

---

1. *My beloved ones:* You must realize that your Master is Merciful. He looks with utmost kindness upon His servant and rejoices when he moves towards Him. He commands the angels in the heavens to welcome him, and to accompany him along the path of light.

   Your Master is kinder than the kindest parent. Therefore, O you who are fleeing from the mercy of your hospitable and compassionate Master, come back. Your Master is waiting eagerly for you at the gates of His mercy. Lest you may fall into merciless hands, He has sent His beloved messenger to guide you to the right path, and to warn you from pitfalls. Yet, He sees that you still reject His hospitality which awaits you. He sees you surrounding yourself with your enemies who took you as their captive, placed chains around your neck and your feet, and isolated you in the prison of remotion and darkness. Your Almighty Master expects you to remember Him and to call upon Him, that He may guide you out of the darkness and into the light. Your Master is close to you. If you turn to Him with all your mind, all your soul, you will find Him right by you, saying, "Welcome, welcome, my beloved one." He is ready and willing to forgive your past rejection of His guidance, and for as long as you place your heart with Him, your Master will be with you.

   The door is wide open; acceptance and forgiveness appear through it. Your Master misses you. Move towards Him, even one step, and He will run towards you, happily welcoming you; fulfilling your needs;

admitting you into the abode of dignity and honor; clothing you with garments of happiness, satisfaction, and acceptance.

2. *My beloved ones:* If you really wish to be slaves of God, you should submit to your Master without reservations, and behave like slaves. When your Master sees this from you, and finds you consistently in His servitude, He will surely fulfill your needs and defend you. Can anyone humiliate a slave whose Master possesses all dignity and all power?

3. *My beloved ones:* If you want your Master to be pleased with you, you should first be pleased with Him; pleased with whatever He ordains. When you see someone dissatisfied and unhappy with your deeds, you will certainly be displeased with him. The satisfaction of your Master starts with your own satisfaction.

4. *Dear beloved ones:* If you reflect very carefully, you will realize that your Master, the possessor of all dignity and all power, actively provides for your needs while you're asleep. When you wake up, you take His provisions and employ them in the very things that displease your Master. He does not treat you with justice; He is much too kind for mere justice. He treats you with grace and compassion, that you may treat Him rightly some day. He sees you persistent in sinning, but He continues to be Clement with you, and extends to you the rope of respite and generosity; He keeps the door of repentance wide open, that you may return to Him.

5. *Dear beloved ones:* Your hearts are where your love is. Therefore, you shall place your love in the hands of your Master, that your hearts may be at Him.

6. *My beloved ones:* Instinctively, the hearts love whoever is good to them. But I see you not loving your Master, who created you, showered you with His bounties, and treated you with clemency and kindness.

7. *Dear beloved ones:* When the slave runs away from his Master, and befriends other fleeing slaves, he deprives himself from the care of his Master, and removes himself out of His sight.

8. *Dear beloved ones:* Have you found anyone better than your Master; a better substitute whom you can love? If you were on the right path, you would find that your Master is the only real love.

9. *Dear beloved ones:* Your Lord is Benign to His slaves, and He loves those who are benign to them. Therefore, if you want Him to be kind to you, you shall have mercy upon His slaves; especially the weak and the poor among them, for they have none to help them except their Master.

10. *My beloved in (the cause of) God:* Whatever you feel in your hearts of hatred and envy is but the result of the devil's occupation of your hearts. Therefore, you shall purge your hearts by trusting and loving the creatures of God.

The Invocations of ʿAbdullāh Anṣārī : 1

ʿAbdullāh Anṣārī, a famous Persian Sufi, was born in Herat 396 AH (1005 C.E.). It is said that one of his ancestors was a companion of the prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) who moved to Herat with ʿAṣāf, son of Qays. Anṣārī's father, Abu Manṣūr Muḥammad Anṣārī, became a permanent resident of Herat.

These invocations, translated into English by Sir Jogendra Singh, contain true advice to guide the Pilgrim along the path of discipleship to the temple of peace. They come from a man who himself had trodden the path and found what his heart desired.

When ʿAbdullāh Anṣārī departed from this world, he was 85 years old, leaving behind a wealth of Sufi knowledge. Among his well-known works are **Risāla Munājāt** *(The Book of Prayer),* **Tabaqat-ul-Ṣūfiyyah** *(The Book of Sufis),* **Zād-ul-ʿĀrifīn** *(Provisions of the Sufi Teachers), and* **Kitāb-i-Isrār** *(The Book of Mysteries).*

In the name of God,
Most Gracious,
Most Merciful.

O Thou Munificent One
Who art the bestower
Of all bounties,
O Thou wise One
Who overlookest our faults,

O Self-existent One
Who art beyond our comprehension,
O Thou omnipotent One
Who hast no equal in power and greatness,
Who art without a second:
O Thou merciful One

ISLAM 1394/1974, 1(1): 67-69

THE INVOCATIONS OF 'ABDULLĀH ANṢĀRĪ : 1

Who guidest stray souls to the right path,
Thou art truly our God.

Give purity to our minds,
Aspiration to our hearts,
Light to our eyes.
Out of Thy grace and bounty
Give us that which Thou deemest best.

O Lord, Out of Thy grace give faith and light
to our hearts.
And with the medicine of truth and steadfastness
cure the ills of our life.

I know not what to ask of Thee,
Thou art the Knower.
Give that which Thou deemest best.

O Lord! I have wasted my life,
Injured my soul,
And pleased the accursed Satan.

My being or not being is of little worth.
Accept my repentance and forgive my sins,
Take me from sorrow to happiness.

From the consequence of my past actions
And perils of the future
I see no way of escape.
O Lord! I am afraid of the evil within me.

Teach me how to save myself
from the snares of self;
Take me by the hand,
For without Thy mercy I have no refuge.

O God, may my brain reel with thoughts of Thee,
May my heart thrill with the mysteries of Thy grace,
May my tongue move only to utter
Thy praise.

I live only to do Thy will,
My lips move only in praise of Thee,
O Lord, whoever becometh aware of Thee
Casteth out all else other than Thee.

He who becom
What use hath
For children, f

Whom Thou i
On him bestow
But Thy mad
What use hath

He who becometh aware of Thee
What use hath he for life,
For children, family or earthly things?

Whom Thou intoxicatest with Thy love
On him bestoweth Thou both the worlds.
But Thy mad devotee,
What use hath he for both the worlds?

Faith is necessary for religions, but it ceases to be so for those who go further and who achieve self-realization in God. Then one no longer believes because one sees. There is no longer any need to believe, when one sees the Truth.

Aḥmad b. Muṣṭafā Al-'Alawī



Islamic Concentrates

Index to the Qur'an : 1

Tells you where to find what in the Qur'an. Since some translators have arbitrarily changed the sequence of the verses and/or suras of their renditions, this index applies only to those Qur'anic printings which adhere to the original Qur'an as approved by Al-Azhar University.

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
A	13	As a Qur'anic Initial	2. Al-Baqarah	1
			3. Āli-'Imrān	1
			7. Al-A'rāf	1
			10. Yūnus	1
			11. Hūd	1
			12. Yūsuf	1
			13. Al-Ra'd	1
			14. Ibrāhīm	1
			15. Al-Ḥijr	1
			29. Al-'Ankabūt	1
			30. Al-Rūm	1
			31. Luqmān	1
			32. Al-Sajdah	1
Aaron	20	Relics left by Moses and Aaron	2. Al-Baqarah	248
		Muḥammad inspired like Noah, Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob, the Patriarchs, Jesus, Job, Jonah, Aaron, Solomon, and David	4. Al-Nisā'	163
		From the progeny of Abraham	6. Al-An'ām	84
		The Pharaoh's magicians believe in Moses and Aaron	7. Al-A'rāf	122
		Asked by Moses to take his place during Moses' absence for 40 days	7. Al-A'rāf	142
		Sent by God, together with Moses, to admonish Pharaoh	10. Yūnus	75
		Ancestor of Mary	19. Maryam	28
		Appointed as an assistant of Moses	19. Maryam	53

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
Aaron (cont'd.)	20	Moses prays to God to have Aaron as a helper	20. Ṭā Hā	30
		The Pharaoh's magicians fall prostrate before the Lord of Moses and Aaron	20. Ṭā Hā	70
		Admonishes the Israelites against worshiping the golden calf	20. Ṭā Hā	90
		Moses blames him for the Israelites' aberrance	20. Ṭā Hā	92
		The statute book given to Moses and Aaron	21. Al-Anbyā'	48
		Moses and his brother Aaron supported by signs from God and authority	23. Al-Mu'minūn	45
		Moses given the scripture, while Aaron was his assistant	25. Al-Furqān	35
		Moses asks God to appoint Aaron as his helper	26. Al-Shu'arā'	13
		The Pharaoh's magicians declare their belief in the Lord of Moses and Aaron	26. Al-Shu'arā'	48
		Aaron more eloquent than Moses; Moses seeks to have him as an assistant	28. Al-Qaṣaṣ	34
		God bestowed His favors upon Moses and Aaron	37. Al-Ṣāffāt	114
		God's blessings and peace upon Moses and Aaron	37. Al-Ṣāffāt	120
Abel	—	The story of Abel and Cain; the first murder	5. Al-Mā'idah	27-31
Ablution	2	The minor ablution (Wuḍū')	5. Al-Mā'idah	6
		The major ablution (Ghusl)	4. Al-Nisā'	43
Abortion	4	Condemned	6. Al-An'ām	140
		Prohibited	6. Al-An'ām 17. Al-Isrā'	151 31
		Righteous women do not commit it	60. Al-Mumtaḥinah	12
Abraham	69	Put to the test	2. Al-Baqarah	124

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
Abraham (cont'd.)	69	His station is to be used as a mosque	2. Al-Baqarah	125
		Commanded, together with Ishmael, to sanctify the House of God	2. Al-Baqarah	125
		Prays to make Mecca a peaceful place	2. Al-Baqarah	126
		Laid the foundations of the Ka'ba	2. Al-Baqarah	127
		Those who foresake Abraham's religion wrong themselves	2. Al-Baqarah	130
		Abraham enjoins Islam upon his children	2. Al-Baqarah	132
		The children of Jacob worship the God of Abraham	2. Al-Baqarah	133
		The religion of Abraham enjoined upon Muslims	2. Al-Baqarah	135
		Muslims enjoined to believe in what was revealed to Abraham	2. Al-Baqarah	136
		Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian	2. Al-Baqarah	140
		The king argues with Abraham about God	2. Al-Baqarah	258
		Abraham declares that his Lord grants life and death	2. Al-Baqarah	258
		Abraham declares that God brings the sun every morning from the East and asks the defiant king to bring it from the West	2. Al-Baqarah	258
		Abraham asks God to show him how He resurrects the dead	2. Al-Baqarah	260
		The family of Abraham among God's chosen messengers	3. Āli-'Imrān	33
		The followers of scriptures argue about Abraham	3. Āli-'Imrān	65
		Abraham was a monotheist; a Muslim	3. Āli-'Imrān	67
		Muḥammad and the Muslims are more deserving of Abraham	3. Āli-'Imrān	68
		Muḥammad enjoined to believe in what was revealed to Abraham	3. Āli-'Imrān	84

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
Abraham (cont'd.)	69	Mankind enjoined to follow the religion of Abraham, monotheism	3. Āli-'Imrān	95
		Abraham's footprints preserved on rock by the Ka'ba as a perpetual miracle	3. Āli-'Imrān	97
		The family of Abraham endowed with the scripture, wisdom, and a great authority	4. Al-Nisā'	54
		Muḥammad enjoined to follow the monotheistic faith of Abraham	4. Al-Nisā'	125
		God takes Abraham as a beloved friend	4. Al-Nisā'	125
		Abraham and his progeny receive God's revelations	4. Al-Nisā'	163
		Abraham questions his father about the idol-worship	6. Al-An'ām	74
		Abraham shown the glory of the heavens and the earth	6. Al-An'ām	75
		Supported by sign from God	6. Al-An'ām	83
		Muḥammad follows the straight path of Abraham's monotheistic faith	6. Al-An'ām	161
		The people of Abraham set up as example for mankind	9. Al-Tawbah	70
		Abraham asks for forgiveness of his father only because he promised him to do so	9. Al-Tawbah	114
		When Abraham realized that his father was an enemy of God, he disowned him	9. Al-Tawbah	114
		Two angels deliver good news to Abraham regarding the birth of Isaac	11. Hūd	69
		Abraham tries to defend the people of Sodom	11. Hūd	74
		Characterized by clemency, obedience, and piety	11. Hūd	75
		Abraham told not to defend the people of Sodom because God's judgment has been issued regarding them	11. Hūd	76

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
Abraham (cont'd.)	69	Joseph endowed like his ancestors, Abraham and Isaac	12. Yūsuf	6
		Joseph follows the religion of his ancestors, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob	12. Yūsuf	38
		Abraham prays for Mecca to be a peaceful place	14. Ibrāhīm	35
		Angels visit Abraham	15. Al-Ḥijr	51
		Abraham was obedient to God; a monotheist	16. Al-Naḥl	120
		Muḥammad inspired into following Abraham's monotheistic religion	16. Al-Naḥl	123
		To be mentioned in the Qur'an as a great prophet	19. Maryan	41
		His father argues with him for foresaking the worship of idols	19. Maryam	46
		Many prophets came from his progeny	19. Maryam	58
		Abraham endowed with wisdom	21. Al-Anbyā'	51
		Recalled as the young man who threatened to destroy the idols	21. Al-Anbyā'	60
		Questioned about destruction of the idols	21. Al-Anbyā'	62
		The fire commanded to be cool and safe for Abraham	21. Al-Anbyā'	69
		Guided to the place for building the Ka'ba	22. Al-Ḥajj	26
		Muḥammad told that Abraham too had been rejected by his people	22. Al-Ḥajj	43
		The name "Muslims" initiated by Abraham	22. Al-Ḥajj	78
		Muḥammad enjoined to mention the history of Abraham	26. Al-Shu'arā'	69
		Preaches to his people the worship of God and righteousness	29. Al-'Ankabūt	16
		Angel messengers of God bring good news to Abraham	29. Al-'Ankabūt	31

Key Word	Frequency of Occurrence	Subject	Sura	Verse No.
Abraham (cont'd.)	69	A pledge taken from the prophets including Muḥammad, Noah, Abraham, Moses, and Jesus	33. Al-Aḥzāb	7
		A follower of Noah	37. Al-Ṣāffāt	83
		Informed that he passed the test of his Lord	37. Al-Ṣāffāt	104
		God's peace bestowed upn him	37. Al-Ṣāffāt	109
		Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob selected and honored	38. Ṣād	45
		Abraham's message part of Islam	42. Al-Shūrā	13
		Disavows the practice of his father and his folk	43. Al-Zukhruf	26
		Angels as his guests	51. Al-Dhāriyat	24
		Fulfilled the commandments	53. Al-Najm	37
		Prophethood placed in his progeny	57. Al-Ḥadīd	26
		Abraham and his followers set up as good example	60. Al-Mumtaḥinah	4
		Promises his father to pray for his forgiveness	60. Al-Mumtaḥinah	4
		Was given a scripture like Moses	87. Al-A'lā	19

The Islamic Calendar Conversion Table : 1

(Hijra / Gregorian)

Over the first five issues of ISLAM, the Journal will publish this table for convenient conversion of dates from either of the two calendar systems. Such chronological conversion tables have been difficult to find yet most indispensible for the Western scholar of Islam. Since all great works of Islamic literature refer exclusively to Hijra dates, the Editors feel that these tables will be useful to many readers.

According to the historians, the prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings be upon him) arrived at Medina on the 12th day of Rabī' I, coincident with September 24, 622 CE (Christian Era). This sets the first day of the first Hijra year (Muḥarram 1, 1) as July 16, 622. Fifteen hundred Hijra years will be covered in these tables (622-2076 CE).

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
1	July 16, 622
2	July 5, 623
3	June 24, 624
4	June 13, 625
5	June 2, 626
6	May 23, 627
7	May 11, 628
8	May 1, 629
9	April 20, 630
10	April 9, 631
11	March 29, 632
12	March 18, 633
13	March 7, 634
14	February 25, 635
15	February 14, 636
16	February 12, 637
17	January 23, 638
18	January 12, 639

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
19	January 2, 640
20	December 21, 640
21	December 10, 641
22	November 30, 642
23	November 19, 643
24	November 7, 644
25	October 28, 645
26	October 17, 646
27	October 7, 647
28	September 25, 648
29	September 14, 649
30	September 4, 650
31	August 24, 651
32	August 12, 652
33	August 2, 653
34	July 22, 654
35	July 11, 655
36	June 30, 656

ISLAM 1394/1974, 1(1): 77-80

THE ISLAMIC CALENDAR CONVERSION TABLE : 1

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
37	June 19, 657
38	June 9, 658
39	May 29, 659
40	May 17, 660
41	May 7, 661
42	April 26, 662
43	April 15, 663
44	April 4, 664
45	March 24, 665
46	March 13, 666
47	March 3, 667
48	February 20, 668
49	February 9, 669
50	January 29, 670
51	January 18, 671
52	January 8, 672
53	December 27, 672
54	December 16, 673
55	December 6, 674
56	November 28, 675
57	November 14, 676
58	November 3, 677
59	October 23, 678
60	October 13, 679
61	October 1, 680
62	September 20, 681
63	September 10, 682
64	August 30, 683
65	August 18, 684
66	August 8, 685
67	July 28, 686
68	July 18, 687
69	July 6, 688
70	June 25, 689
71	June 15, 690
72	June 4, 691
73	May 23, 692
74	May 13, 693
75	May 2, 694
76	April 21, 695
77	April 10, 696
78	March 30, 697
79	March 20, 698
80	March 9, 699
81	February 26, 700
82	February 15, 701
83	February 4, 702
84	January 24, 703
85	January 14, 704

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
86	January 2, 705
87	December 23, 705
88	December 12, 706
89	December 1, 707
90	November 20, 708
91	November 9, 709
92	October 29, 710
93	October 19, 711
94	October 7, 712
95	September 26, 713
96	September 16, 714
97	September 5, 715
98	August 25, 716
99	August 14, 717
100	August 3, 718
101	July 24, 719
102	July 12, 720
103	July 1, 721
104	June 21, 722
105	June 10, 723
106	May 29, 724
107	May 19, 725
108	May 8, 726
109	April 28, 727
110	April 16, 728
111	April 5, 729
112	March 26, 730
113	March 15, 731
114	March 3, 732
115	February 21, 733
116	February 10, 734
117	January 31, 735
118	January 20, 736
119	January 8, 737
120	December 29, 737
121	December 18, 738
122	December 7, 739
123	November 26, 740
124	November 15, 741
125	November 4, 742
126	October 25, 743
127	October 13, 744
128	October 3, 745
129	September 22, 746
130	September 11, 747
131	August 31, 748
132	August 20, 749
133	August 9, 750
134	July 30, 751

THE ISLAMIC CALENDAR CONVERSION TABLE : 1

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
135	July 18, 752
136	July 7, 753
137	June 27, 754
138	June 16, 755
139	June 5, 756
140	May 25, 757
141	May 14, 758
142	May 4, 759
143	April 22, 760
144	April 11, 761
145	April 1, 762
146	March 21, 763
147	March 10, 764
148	February 27, 765
149	February 16, 766
150	February 6, 767
151	January 26, 768
152	January 14, 769
153	January 4, 770
154	December 24, 770
155	December 13, 771
156	December 2, 772
157	November 21, 773
158	November 11, 774
159	October 31, 775
160	October 19, 776
161	October 9, 777
162	September 28, 778
163	September 17, 779
164	September 6, 780
165	August 26, 781
166	August 15, 782
167	August 5, 783
168	July 24, 784
169	July 14, 785
170	July 30, 786
171	June 22, 787
172	June 11, 788
173	May 31, 789
174	May 20, 790
175	May 10, 791
176	April 28, 792
177	April 18, 793
178	April 7, 794
179	March 27, 795
180	March 16, 796
181	March 5, 797
182	February 22, 798
183	February 12, 799

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
184	February 1, 800
185	January 20, 801
186	January 10, 802
187	December 30, 802
188	December 20, 803
189	December 8, 804
190	November 27, 805
191	November 17, 806
192	November 6, 807
193	October 25, 808
194	October 15, 809
195	October 4, 810
196	September 23, 811
197	September 12, 812
198	September 1, 813
199	August 22, 814
200	August 11, 815
201	July 30, 816
202	July 20, 817
203	July 9, 818
204	June 28, 819
205	June 17, 820
206	June 6, 821
207	May 27, 822
208	May 16, 823
209	May 4, 824
210	April 24, 825
211	April 13, 826
212	April 2, 827
213	March 22, 828
214	March 11, 829
215	February 28, 830
216	February 18, 831
217	February 7, 832
218	January 27, 833
219	January 16, 834
220	January 5, 835
221	December 26, 835
222	December 14, 836
223	December 3, 837
224	November 23, 838
225	November 12, 839
226	October 31, 840
227	October 21, 841
228	October 10, 842
229	September 30, 843
230	September 18, 844
231	September 7, 845
232	August 28, 846

THE ISLAMIC CALENDAR CONVERSION TABLE : 1

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
233	August 17, 847
234	August 5, 848
235	July 26, 849
236	July 15, 850
237	July 5, 851
238	June 23, 852
239	June 12, 853
240	June 2, 854
241	May 22, 855
242	May 10, 856
243	April 30, 857
244	April 19, 858
245	April 8, 859
246	March 28, 860
247	March 17, 861
248	March 7, 862
249	February 24, 863
250	February 13, 864
251	February 2, 865
252	January 22, 866
253	January 11, 867
254	January 1, 868
255	December 20, 868
256	December 9, 869
257	November 29, 870
258	November 18, 871
259	November 7, 872
260	October 27, 873
261	October 16, 874
262	October 6, 875
263	September 24, 876
264	September 13, 877
265	September 3, 878
266	August 23, 879

First Day of the Hijra Year No.	COINCIDES WITH (Gregorian Date)
267	August 12, 880
268	August 1, 881
269	July 21, 882
270	July 11, 883
271	June 29, 884
272	June 18, 885
273	June 8, 886
274	May 28, 887
275	May 16, 888
276	May 6, 889
277	April 25, 890
278	April 15, 891
279	April 3, 892
280	March 23, 893
281	March 13, 894
282	March 2, 895
283	February 19, 896
284	February 8, 897
285	January 28, 898
286	January 17, 899
287	January 7, 900
288	December 26, 900
289	December 16, 901
290	December 5, 902
291	November 24, 903
292	November 13, 904
293	November 2, 905
294	October 22, 906
295	October 12, 907
296	September 30, 908
297	September 20, 909
298	September 9, 910
299	August 29, 911
300	August 18, 912

Book Review

Race and Color in Islam ***by Bernard Lewis.*** Harper & Row, New York, 1971. 104 pages, $2.25.

According to Bernard Lewis, a host of people including blacks like Malcolm X and whites like Arnold Toynbee, have been deceived by the "myth" of Islamic racial equality. His purpose in this book, he says, is "to correct the false pictures drawn by the myth-makers, the picture of the total absence of such evils (of race and color prejudice) . . . to refute the claims . . . of exclusive virtue . . . and to point to certain common failings of our common humanity." (p. 102). Lewis' attempt is not novel. In 1967 a black Christian preacher, the Reverend Albert Cleage, delivered a widely-published speech in which he made a similar charge with reference to the conversion of Malcolm X to Islam: "According to the myth, his pilgrimage to Mecca turned Brother Malcolm into an integrationist . . . I say I do not believe this myth . . . He would not have been taken in by what happened in Mecca. Brother Malcolm knew that the Arab Muslims had been the backbone of the slave trade." (*Malcolm X, The Man and His Times,* ed. by John Henrik Clarke, Collier Books, N.Y., 1969, pp. 14, 15.). I recall reading a piece in *The Washington Post* newspaper in 1969 which asserted similarly that Arab Muslims were "the most notorious slave traders in history." The Cleage speech may be passed off as simple religious rivalry. The *Post* article was written in the context of questioning why so many black Americans are becoming Muslims. Lewis, however, comes in the guise of the dispassionate, objective scholar.

It is strange that the book is titled *Race and Color in Islam,* since its primary purpose is the attempt to document racism and color prejudice as practiced by a few Muslim individuals. The first flaw is that Lewis does not know what Islam is. He gives the Qur'an and the example of Prophet Muḥammad (peace be upon him) only passing mention, but spends a lot of time with *The Arabian Nights.* As his book develops it is clear that, for him, Islam means "not what Muslims believed or were expected to believe but what they actually did." (p. 6). For this reason, his entire study lacks validity. His basic working premise is false; therefore, his conclusions are false. Islam is what Muslims do *in obedience to the Qur'an and the example of Muḥammad.* That which is done contrary to the letter or spirit of Islam is not Islam, even if the doer is a Muslim, as is made clear in several *Aḥādith* reported by Bukhāri and Muslim. (See *Mishkat al-Maṣabīḥ,* vol. 1, pp. 17, 19.). Racial prejudice and slave trading do not represent Islam, even if practiced by some Muslims, because both are against the principles upon which Islam stands.

Secondly, to follow to its logical conclusion a train of thought and "evidence" such as Lewis presents, one would be forced to concede that genocide is the essence of Christianity merely because Hitler was a Catholic, or that Christ (peace be upon him) was a racist simply because South Africa is a "Christian" country. It is indeed possible to be scholarly absurd and this book is a prime example of scholarly absurdity. Lewis carefully picks and chooses "facts" to suit his argument, even while admitting that many of his references are questionable and do not represent the complete picture, while passing over a mass of evidence which disputes his claims.

No one will deny that Islam, the system of liberation, equality and freedom, had to wage a hard struggle in order to eradicate pride of tribe and race from the hearts of the people with whom it came in contact. It is also true that some people were not cured completely of their prejudices immediately, and there were those in the *dār-ul-Islam* who, from time to time, slipped back into their old vices. But these are normal human failings, not failure of the system. During the time of the Prophet (peace be upon him), a certain companion taunted another by calling him "Ibn al-saudā'", "son of the black woman." To Muḥammad, a member of the noblest Arab tribe of Quraysh, such prejudice was nothing but pure ignorance (Jahiliyya). (Bukhari 2:21). The bulk of examples which Lewis cites of "Islamic" racism are from 900 to 1200 C.E., a period when some Muslims were influenced, not by Islam, but by racial mores of the pagans and Christians. And it is significant that some Muslim chronologists wrote just as disparagingly of white Europeans as they did of pagan Africans: "Thus they lack keenness of understanding and clarity of intelligence, and are overcome by ignorance and dullness, lack of discernment, and stupidity. Such are the Slavs, the Bulgars, and their neighbors." (Sa'īd al-Andalusī of 1029-1070 C.E., quoted on p. 36.).

Lewis admits that Muslims enslaved both black and white captives of war, but insists that the trade in black slaves was evidence of Muslim racial discrimination. This *non sequitur* is typical of his shallow scholarship. If racial prejudice existed to even a fraction of the extent he claims, there never would have been the great black Islamic empires of West Africa which arose from 850 C.E. on and flourished, establishing extensive diplomatic, cultural and economic relations with the Muslim east as well as Muslim North Africa. It is strange that Europeans like Lewis (and some misinformed blacks) attempt to tag Islam as worse in slave trading than European Christianity, whereas African writers themselves highlight the vast difference: "(Slave trading by Muslims) did not compare in extent with the slave trade later carried on across the Atlantic. The demand for household slaves was less than the demand for plantation slaves; nor was it possible to transport by land, across the desert, the large numbers that could be packed into ships. Their fate

at their destination was likely to be preferable to what met slaves in America. In Muslim society a slave could rise to a high place . . . Nor was Muslim slavery based on color. Though the slaves exported across the Sahara were all Africans, many Muslim households in North Africa also had European slaves, captured in war . . . The famous (black) king Mansa Musa of Mali, when he visited Cairo on his pilgrimage to Mecca (in 1324 C.E.), bought white Turkish slaves there to take home with him." (*A Thousand Years of West African History,* ed. by A. Ajaye, U. of Ibadan Press, Nigeria, 1965, p. 245.). Arab slavery on Africa's east coast was also much smaller in volume than was the European slave trade. (See *Africa and Africans* by Paul Bohannan, The Natural History Press, N.Y., 1964, p. 108.)

Islam allowed the enslavement of war captives so long as the enemy enslaved Muslims captured in war. However, the emphasis in the Qur'an and in the example of the Prophet (peace be upon him) was of liberating slaves as quickly as possible. Kidnapping people to enslave them, and trading in slaves for economic gain has always been forbidden in Islam. Therefore, those few Muslims who engaged in *slave trading* were not representative of Islam, but were following their own desires or imitating the European Christians, for whom slave trading eventually became big business. But it is clear even so that those Muslims who did engage in slaving did not do so for racial discrimination against Africans, as Lewis suggests. Under Arab and African slavery, slaves were treated as human beings with recognized rights. Nor were slaves considered *inherently inferior* due to their color, but merely victims of adverse circumstances.

Islam is the only system of life which not merely advocated the liberation of slaves but which also *provided incentives* for people to become liberators. In Qur'an 4:92, for example, the concept of *taḥrīru raqabah* "freeing the neck," i.e., libertaing a slave is mentioned three times as a ransom for one's own sins. Similarly, in Qur'an 5:92 God says: "In order to atone (or seek remission) . . . liberate a slave *(taḥrīru raqabah).*" In Qur'an 2:177 we are told: "It is righteousness . . . to spend money, despite one's love thereof . . . for the liberation of slaves." And at Qur'an 90:12, 13 God says: "And what will explain to you the exalted path (of true belief)? It is to emancipate a slave *(fakku raqabah)* . . ." Furthermore, the gradual emancipation practiced by the early Muslims, in accordance with the Qur'anic instructions, was an act of social welfare which worked to ease the rigors of readjustment to the life and responsibilities of the free man. This contrasts most favorably to the example of American emancipation, during which ex-slaves were merely cast off without proper resources to provide for themselves, so that even a hundred years later, the descendants of ex-slaves in America face crushing social and economic problems.

Lewis recognizes that racist attitudes and acts among the Muslims

throughout history "seem to have been rare" (p. 98), yet he uses the major portion of his book to dig up all the rare, titillating bits of ambiguous information he can find, so as to infuse them with his own interpretations. (It should be noted that all of his documentation from Arabic, Turkish and Persian sources is presented in translation only. He does not give the original texts.). He could not, and did not, undermine the basic fact that *Islam* is *based on complete racial equality.* Racism in the vast Muslim world was confined to a few stray individuals. Never has racism become an official State National Institution. No Muslim country ever established "Jim Crow" or Apartheid. Perhaps the real reason for publication of this absurd book should be sought elsewhere, in the fact that so many black Americans and young liberal whites are accepting Islam as a way of life. Someone, obviously, is displeased with this turn of events.

S. Shāhid Mufassir

Advertising Rates

Cover & Special Positions	$135
Full Page	$105
Half Page	$ 50
Quarter Page	$ 35

All communications regarding advertising matters should be addressed to:

ADVERTISEMENT SECTION

ISLAM

P. O. Box 12202

St. Louis, Missouri 63157

Announcing

a NEW Book from a NEW Publisher

MIRACLE OF THE QUR'AN

Significance of the Mysterious Alphabets.

RASHAD KHALIFA, Ph.D.

First computerized study of the Qur'an. Providing physical, examinable evidence that the Qur'an is the Word of God.

Undisputable proof that the scriptural miracles such as the virgin birth of Christ and Moses' miracles in Egypt, did indeed take place.

A book for all people of all faiths. $6.80

Published by:

ISLAMIC PRODUCTIONS INTERNATIONAL
Box 12202, St. Louis, Missouri 63157

A clearing house of information about Islam.

Inquire about our Islamic Sound Recordings.

Let your students HEAR *the sounds of Islam as they learn about it.*

ESSENTIALS OF ISLAM on Tape Cassettes. $5.50

IT is held that when a Seeker gives his heart and mind to the search, and disperses the mists that arise from tumultuous passions, Truth becomes brighter and brighter and fills the Soul with its light.

It is asserted that while reason is puzzling itself about mystery of consciousness, time, and space, the man of Faith is going forward from discovery to discovery, in the growing illumination of his heart.

But it must be recognised that this knowledge is only available to those whose eyes are fixed, like an archer, on the arrow and the object at which he aims, and that without purity of purpose and unceasing effort deliverance cannot be obtained.

In all ages and in all times men have sought and found truth. They have shown the way and means of attainment. But men have listened to the message with incredulity and continued the mad pursuit of sense objects.

Passions of body and mind govern men and kindle fires of desire, of greed, attachment, egoism and anger. These enslave and obscure the mind which must be freed, and restored to its pristine purity to reflect truth. The seekers of truth, therefore, concentrate all their strength in drawing away the mind from sense objects and to set it free from the dominations of fear and hate. Some follow the path of knowledge, and others the path of devotion, hoping to lose all sense of duality in the supreme uprising of love.

(from Preface of "The Invocations of 'Abdullāh Anṣārī")



THE ISLAMIC CALENDAR
1394

3 – RABI'1, 1394

MARCH 25 – APRIL 22, 1974

FRI.	SAT.	SUN.	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.
			1 MAR. 25	2 26	3 27	4 28
5 29	6 30	7 31	8 APR. 1	9 2	10 3	11 4
12 5	13 6	14 7	15 8	16 9	17 10	18 11
19 12	20 13	21 14	22 15	23 16	24 17	25 18
26 19	27 20	28 21	29 22			

4 – RABI' II, 1394

APRIL 23 – MAY 22, 1974

FRI.	SAT.	SUN.	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.
				1 APR. 23	2 24	3 25
4 26	5 27	6 28	7 29	8 30	9 MAY 1	10 2
11 3	12 4	13 5	14 6	15 7	16 8	17 9
18 10	19 11	20 12	21 13	22 14	23 15	24 16
25 17	26 18	27 19	28 20	29 21	30 22	

5 – JUMADA I, 1394

MAY 23 – JUNE 20, 1974

FRI.	SAT.	SUN.	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.
						1 MAY 23
2 24	3 25	4 26	5 27	6 28	7 29	8 30
9 31	10 JUNE 1	11 2	12 3	13 4	14 5	15 6
16 7	17 8	18 9	19 10	20 11	21 12	22 13
23 14	24 15	25 16	26 17	27 18	28 19	29 20